



United Nations Security Council

Background Guide



Agenda:

**“De-escalating the Conflagration of
the Israel–Iran Military Conflict.”**

United Nations Security Council

BACKGROUND GUIDE



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Letter From the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

We welcome you to the United Nations Security Council committee simulation at the Welham Boys' School Model United Nations Conference 2026. The world today faces urgent and extraordinarily complex challenges, as nations contend with the immediate consequences of war, conflict and deepening regional instability.

We stand at a diverging road, one whose outcome will determine the future of the international order itself. The existence of sovereign nations is being questioned, and the responsibility of navigating this crisis rests with the delegates. As delegates to this committee, you are required to account for all events that have unfolded between March 2, 2026 and July 28, 2026, as documented in the timeline provided to you by the Executive Board. As members of the most consequential body within the United Nations framework, you are tasked with stabilising a world on a dangerous slope; one where negotiations have grown insurmountable, and where further delay risks catastrophe of an irreversible scale.

The committee will deliberate on the agenda: **"De-Escalating the Conflagration of the Israel–Iran Military Conflict."** The region is shaken and disturbed with instability that threatens to draw the entire world into chaos. What were once characterised as ideological and religious tensions of a contained nature have now escalated into full-scale military confrontation, inflicting devastation on all parties involved and causing severe disruptions to global economic and geopolitical stability. The months preceding this session have witnessed a rapid and alarming succession of developments. Delegates would be required to engage with the totality of the provided timeline and to ground all debate, resolution, and negotiation in the realities it establishes.

It must be understood that the nature of this crisis is singularly dynamic. We stand closer to the brink of a Third World War than at any point in recent history. This is not a bilateral conflict in the manner of Russia–Ukraine or India–Pakistan. This is a multi-actor conflagration in which old grievances and new ambitions converge in a dangerously unstable equilibrium in which the involvement of great powers, regional actors, non-state entities, and corporate infrastructure has rendered the conventional architecture of international diplomacy deeply insufficient.

Delegates are expected to disentangle the web of escalation and work toward sustainable de-escalation, while maintaining the foreign policy positions of their respective member states. Your mandate is not merely to react to events already in motion, but to address the structural conditions that have allowed this crisis to reach its current threshold. The Security Council was established to succeed where the League of Nations failed. Whether through the imposition of sanctions, formal condemnation, the negotiation of ceasefires, the deployment of peacekeeping mechanisms, or any other instrument within the Council's jurisdiction, your decisions must serve one singular purpose: to ensure that humanity does not cross the threshold into a third world war. You are the final institutional buffer between order and collapse.



This is not a utopian international order in which any form of goodwill prevails and multilateralism functions as designed. This is a world in which leaders driven by nationalist ambition have plunged entire regions into conflict. Where conservative and authoritarian ideologies have systematically displaced liberal international norms. Where diplomacy has been reduced to a procedural formality, and multilateral institutions have been repurposed as instruments of great power competition. It is no longer nations alone that dictate the terms of engagement corporations, military alliances, intelligence apparatuses, and rogue actors have each claimed a seat at the table. In this reality, global welfare is consistently subordinated to strategic gain.

The Executive Board will reward on-spot high order thinking as much as we will reward good research. Though being well versed with the agenda at hand will hold great value, it is ultimately your wit to be able to implement these ideas that count.

We look forward to witnessing quality research, depth of analysis, and clarity of decision-making that each delegate brings to this committee. The world does not have the luxury of time.

Now, it all rests in the hands of the members of the Security Council.

Warm Regards,
The Executive Board
United Nations Security Council

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Note: The deadline for the submission of position papers is 18th July, 2026.



About the Committee: United Nations Security Council

Significance and History

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations (UN), responsible for maintaining international peace and security, recommending the admission of new UN members to the General Assembly, and approving amendments to the UN Charter. Its powers, as outlined in the United Nations Charter, include establishing peacekeeping operations, enacting international sanctions, and authorizing military action. The UNSC is the only UN body with the authority to issue resolutions that are binding on member states.

Established after World War II to address the failures of the League of Nations in maintaining global peace, the Security Council held its first session on January 17, 1946. However, its effectiveness was limited during the ensuing Cold War due to political deadlock between the United States and the Soviet Union (and their respective allies). Despite this, the UNSC authorized military interventions in the Korean War and the Congo Crisis, as well as peacekeeping missions in Cyprus, West New Guinea, and the Sinai Peninsula. Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, UN peacekeeping efforts expanded significantly, with major missions authorized in Kuwait, Namibia, Cambodia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Rwanda, Somalia, Sudan, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Security Council resolutions are typically enforced by UN peacekeepers, consisting of military forces voluntarily contributed by member states and funded separately from the main UN budget. As of November 2030, there were 11 active peacekeeping missions involving over 87,000 personnel from 128 countries, with an annual budget of approximately \$8.9 billion.

Mandate

The United Nations Charter established six main organs of the United Nations, including the Security Council. It gives primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security to the Security Council, which may meet whenever peace is threatened.

According to the Charter, the United Nations has four purposes:

- to maintain international peace and security;
- to develop friendly relations among nations;
- to cooperate in solving international problems and in promoting respect for human rights;
- and to be a center for harmonizing the actions of nations.



All members of the United Nations agree to accept and carry out the decisions of the Security Council. While other organs of the United Nations make recommendations to member states, only the Security Council has the power to make decisions that member states are then obligated to implement under the Charter. That said, UN Security Council (UNSC) resolutions adopted under Chapter VII of the UN Charter are legally binding on all UN Member States. These resolutions, which address threats to peace, breaches of the peace, and acts of aggression, carry the force of international law and must be implemented by member nations. Other UNSC resolutions, particularly those under Chapter VI (Pacific Settlement of Disputes), are not legally binding, although they may have political weight.

When a complaint concerning a threat to peace is brought before it, the Council's first action is usually to recommend that the parties try to reach an agreement by peaceful means. The Council may:

- set forth principles for such an agreement;
- undertake investigation and mediation, in some cases.
- dispatch a mission;
- appoint special envoys; or
- request the Secretary-General to use his good offices to achieve a peaceful settlement of the dispute.

When a dispute leads to hostilities, the Council's primary concern is to bring them to an end as soon as possible. In that case, the Council may: Issue ceasefire directives that can help prevent an escalation of the conflict;

- dispatch military observers or a peacekeeping force to help reduce tensions, separate opposing forces, and establish a calm in which peaceful settlements may be sought.
- economic sanctions, arms embargoes, financial penalties and restrictions, and travel bans;
- severance of diplomatic relations;
- blockade and demilitarization;
- or even collective military action.

A chief concern is to focus action on those responsible for the policies or practices condemned by the international community, while minimizing the impact of the measures taken on other parts of the population and economy.

Functions and Power

Under the United Nations Charter, the functions and powers of the Security Council are:



- to maintain international peace and security in accordance with the principles and purposes of the United Nations;
- to investigate any dispute or situation which might lead to international friction;
- to recommend methods of adjusting such disputes or the terms of settlement;
- to formulate plans for the establishment of a system to regulate armaments;
- to determine the existence of a threat to the peace or act of aggression and to recommend what action should be taken;
- to call on Members to apply economic sanctions and other measures not involving the use of force to prevent or stop aggression;
- to take military action against an aggressor;
- to recommend the admission of new Members;
- to exercise the trusteeship functions of the United Nations in “strategic areas”;
- to recommend to the General Assembly the appointment of the Secretary-General and, together with the Assembly, to elect the Judges of the International Court of Justice

Structure

The UNSC is composed of 15 member states: 5 permanent members and 10 non-permanent members. The permanent members, often referred to as the P5, are China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States. These nations were the principal victors of World War II (or their recognized successor states). The permanent members hold veto power, allowing them to block any substantive Security Council resolution, including those related to the admission of new UN member states or the appointment of the Secretary-General. However, this veto power does not extend to matters in the General Assembly, where votes are non-binding. The remaining ten members are elected on a regional basis for two-year terms. The presidency of the Security Council rotates monthly among its members.

The 10 non-permanent members are elected by the United Nations General Assembly for two-year terms to ensure equitable geographical representation. These seats are allocated as follows:

- 3 seats for the African Group
- 2 seats for the Asia-Pacific Group
- 2 seats for Latin American and Caribbean Group (GRULAC)
- 2 seats for Western European and Others Group (WEOG)
- 1 seat for Eastern European Group

Elections are held annually for five of the ten non-permanent seats, ensuring a rotating composition that balances continuity with fresh perspectives.



Each member of the Security Council, permanent or non-permanent, holds one vote, and decisions on substantive matters (such as sanctions, peacekeeping mandates, or the use of force) require at least 9 affirmative votes, including the concurring votes of all five permanent members (i.e., no vetoes). Procedural matters, on the other hand, require 9 votes and cannot be vetoed.

In addition to the 15 members, observer states and invited parties may be allowed to participate in Council discussions. These include:

- Observer states
- Concerned parties to a conflict or topic under discussion
- Relevant regional organizations or UN agencies

While these entities do not have voting rights on substantive matters, they may be allowed to speak during debates and informal consultations. Notably, observers can participate in procedural votes, depending on the specific rules of engagement determined by the Council at the time.

This structure aims to balance power politics with regional representation, allowing the Council to maintain legitimacy while addressing pressing international peace and security issues.

Flow of the Committee

As the Executive Board, our approach will be largely non-intrusive to ensure the committee functions in-dependently and organically. We will proceed with voting on motions raised in an orderly manner, while only intervening in exceptional circumstances—particularly if the debate stagnates or fails to move toward a meaningful and solution-driven discussion. That said, we reserve the right to suggest changes or steer the debate if necessary to maintain the committee's productivity. In theory, the delegates may vote upon a motion to introduce a draft resolution before the general speakers' list is established, and the executive board will not interfere with such decisions of the committee.

We strongly encourage first-time delegates to actively participate in the proceedings and request experienced delegates to support and include them in discussions. On Day 1, we will begin with an informal briefing on the Rules of Procedure (RoP) before having questions and clarifications on the Rules of Procedures. To maintain engagement and avoid monotony, we encourage each delegate to take at least one Point of Information (POI) during formal speeches, provided the speaker consents and time permits. We look forward to a dynamic, informed, and diplomatic committee experience. Let's strive for thoughtful dialogue and substantive resolutions.

Introduction to the Agenda



The Israel–Iran military confrontation, long shaped by asymmetric operations, proxy networks, and strategic deterrence postures has now escalated into a regional crisis that now threatens to unravel established security of the Middle East. What began as episodic strikes, maritime harassment, and clandestine sabotage has evolved into sustained exchanges and intensified proxy disputes drawn along fault lines that traverse Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, and many more. The convergence of state sponsored covert action, non-state militant escalation, and sophisticated strike capabilities has degraded the stability and undermined traditional channels of de-escalating the conflict. Simultaneously, the conflict’s externalization through maritime security disruptions, threats to energy transit routes, and regional realignments has affected global economic and diplomatic relations between countries beyond the middle east. Compounding these dynamics are weakened regional institutions, fragmented diplomacy, and competing great power interests that often prioritize strategic positioning over immediate conflict deescalating, thereby narrowing political space for restraint. The human cost has been severely paid through civilian casualties and mass immigration. In such a complex environment, piecemeal responses and unilateral escalation risk entrenching a protracted conflagration. Strengthening conflict-management mechanisms, restoring robust channels for crisis communication, and supporting regional platforms for negotiating the de-escalation of this conflict are therefore imperative. This agenda seeks to examine origins, escalation pathways, and viable instruments for de-escalation ranging from localized ceasefire frameworks and maritime safety protocols to confidence building measures aimed at reversing the trajectory toward wider regional war and creating conditions for a sustainable political settlement.

In light of these recent events, the world stands on a fumbling floor. It is our responsibility to stabilize the world and bring order to it.

Context of the Iran-Israel Diplomatic Situation

The Israel–Iran relationship has undergone a dramatic transformation over the past several decades, evolving from practical strategic cooperation into one of the most consequential and volatile rivalries in the Middle East. This conflict is fundamentally shaped by ideological hostility following the 1979 Islamic Revolution, geopolitical competition for regional influence, and persistent security dilemmas. While the two states were once strategic partners in the "alliance of the periphery," the establishment of the Islamic Republic redefined the relationship, replacing cooperation with sustained geopolitical and ideological confrontation.

Over subsequent decades, this rivalry increasingly manifested through non-conventional methods, including proxy warfare, covert operations, cyberattacks, and nuclear tensions across Lebanon, Syria, Iraq, Gaza, and Yemen. In recent years, patterns of indirect confrontation have escalated into unprecedented direct military exchanges, heightening fears of a broader regional conflagration with significant humanitarian, economic, and international security implications.



This historical analysis traces the evolution of Israel–Iran relations from Cold War alignment to the contemporary cycle of direct and proxy confrontation.

I. Origins of Israel–Iran Relations (1948–1979)

When the State of Israel was established in 1948, Iran initially opposed the UN partition plan and voted against Israel's admission to the United Nations. However, this stance shifted by 1950, when Iran became the second Muslim-majority country to recognize the new nation. Under Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi's pro-Western monarchy, the two countries became natural partners through Israel's "alliance of the periphery" strategy. As non-Arab states surrounded by Arab neighbours, they used this partnership to counter shared regional threats, building a relationship based on strategic necessity and mutual survival.

During the 1960s and 1970s, this alliance grew into deep economic and military cooperation. Iran became Israel's primary oil supplier, even jointly operating a pipeline, while Israeli experts and companies were highly active in Iranian development. Beyond trade and informal diplomatic offices, the two nations engaged in secret military ventures, such as a joint missile project in the late 1970s. While religious leaders in Iran criticized this closeness and supported the Palestinian cause, the official bond remained mostly positive and cooperative until the revolution changed everything.

I. *The Periphery Doctrine (Israel)*

The periphery doctrine was developed as a foreign policy strategy by David Ben-Gurion during the early decades of Israel's existence. The doctrine emerged because of Israel being surrounded by hostile Arab states and faced diplomatic isolation in the Middle East. The doctrine was made during the early 1950s, formally being declared in 1958. Since Israel lacked normal relations with many neighbouring countries, Ben-Gurion sought alliances with many non-Arab states and regional minorities in the Arab region.

II. The 1979 Iranian Revolution and Ideological Transformation

The 1979 Islamic Revolution abruptly ended friendly relations between Iran and Israel, with Ayatollah Khomeini's new regime adopting a policy of open hostility, designating Israel an "enemy of Islam" and the "Little Satan." The regime severed all official ties, reassigning the Israeli mission in Tehran to the Palestine Liberation Organization and viewing Israel as a symbol



II.1. Iran under the Shah

After centuries of misrule by its former rulers and the ravages of the war waged by foreign belligerents on its soil from 1914 to 1919, Iran in 1921 was prostrated, ruined, and on the verge of disintegration. This situation led Reza Khan to use the effective and disciplined Persian Cossack Brigade that was at his command to take power and put an end to the chaos. Able to levy some taxes, he built up the army with the proceeds and then used the army to collect more taxes, until finally he had gained control over the entire country.

During the reign of Reza Shah Pahlavi, educational and judicial reforms were effected that laid the basis of a modern state and reduced the influence of the religious classes ('ulamā'). A wide range of legal affairs that had previously been the purview of Shi'i religious courts were now either administered by secular courts or overseen by state bureaucracies, and, as a result, the status of women improved. The custom of women wearing veils was banned, the minimum age for marriage was raised, and strict religious divorce laws (which invariably favoured the husband) were made more equitable.

Reza Shah's need to expand trade, his fear of Soviet control over Iran's overland routes to Europe, and his apprehension at renewed Soviet and continued British presence in Iran drove him to expand trade with Nazi Germany in the 1930s. His refusal to abandon what he considered to be obligations to numerous Germans in Iran served as a pretext for an Anglo-Soviet invasion of his country in 1941.

II.2. Iran under Ruhollah Khomeini

From the mid-1970s, Khomeini's influence inside Iran grew dramatically, owing to mounting public dissatisfaction with the Shah's regime. Iraq's ruler, Saddam Hussein, forced Khomeini to leave Iraq on October 6, 1978. Khomeini then settled in Neauphle-le-Château, a suburb of Paris. From there, his supporters relayed his tape-recorded messages to an increasingly aroused Iranian populace, and massive demonstrations, strikes, and civil unrest in late 1978 forced the departure of the shah from Iran on January 16, 1979. Khomeini arrived in Tehrān in triumph on February 1, 1979, and was acclaimed as the religious leader of Iran's revolution. He announced the formation of a new government four days later, and on February 1, the army declared its neutrality. Khomeini returned to Qom as the clerical class worked to establish their power. A national referendum in April showed overwhelming support for the institution of an Islamic republic, and the constitution of the Islamic Republic was approved in a referendum in December. Khomeini was named rahbar, Iran's political and religious leader for life.

Iran's course of economic development foundered under Khomeini's rule, and his pursuit of victory in the Iran-Iraq War ultimately proved futile. Khomeini, however, was able to retain his charismatic hold over the Shi'ah in Iran, and he remained the supreme political and religious arbiter in the country until his death.



II.3. Emergence of Anti-West Ideology

The anti-West ideology became one of the defining features of post-1979 Iran and deeply influenced its relationship with Israel. Before the Islamic Revolution, Iran under Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi maintained close political and military ties with the United States and also cooperated with Israel. However, many Iranians viewed the Shah as overly dependent on Western powers, particularly after the 1953 coup supported by the United States and Britain that removed Prime Minister Mohammad Mossadegh. This created widespread resentment toward Western influence in Iran's political and economic affairs. After Ayatollah Khomeini came to power in 1979, the new Islamic Republic positioned itself as a state resisting Western dominance and what it described as cultural domination.

This anti-Western outlook also helped the Iranian regime strengthen its domestic legitimacy. By presenting itself as a defender of oppressed Muslims and an opponent of foreign interference, the government was able to unite different sections of society under a revolutionary narrative. Hostility toward the United States and Israel became central to state propaganda, political speeches, and foreign policy decisions. Over time, opposition to Israel evolved from being purely ideological to serving strategic regional interests as well, especially through Iran's support for groups such as Hezbollah and Hamas.

II.4. Emergence of Anti-Zionism

After the establishment of the State of Israel in the 1948 Palestine war, anti-Zionism shifted from opposition to the creation of a Jewish state to opposition to Israel's existence, with many postwar movements advocating its replacement by an alternative political entity. Most Jewish anti-Zionist movements disintegrated or transformed into pro-Zionist organizations, though some, including the American Council for Judaism, continued to oppose the ideology. Outside the Jewish community, opposition to Zionism developed primarily among Arab populations, particularly



Palestinians, after the mass displacement of Palestinian Arabs during the 1948 war, which many Palestinians and scholars consider a form of colonial dispossession

II.5. Severing Diplomatic Ties

The countries of the Islamic Republic of Iran and the State of Israel have had no diplomatic ties for about the past 5 decades, obviously due to the Iranian Revolution. As mentioned above, Iran withdrew its recognition of Israel, classifying it as the Zionist regime.

The current ties between Iran are mainly affected due to the following factors:

1. **The Nuclear Dispute:** Iranian nuclear programs have been a major source of tension, highlighted by large uranium deposits. Israel continues to mount military and intelligence programs to disrupt these capabilities.
2. **Regional Alliances:** Iran backs various militant networks across the Middle East, while Israel continues to press for the global diplomatic isolation of Iran.
3. **International Campaigns:** Israeli leadership has urged countries worldwide to break off diplomatic and economic relations with Iran, citing internal repression and regional hostilities.

II.6. Revolutionary Foreign Policy

Before the 1979 revolution, Iran's foreign policy under the Pahlavi monarchy was strongly pro-Western, secular, and capitalist, acting as a primary U.S. ally and regional protector. After the revolution, it shifted to an anti-imperialist, religion based framework dedicated to "exporting the revolution" and establishing an independent Islamic Republic free from both Western and Communist influence.

Pre-Revolutionary Foreign Policy (Before 1979):

- **Western Alliance:** Iran was the United States' primary strategic partner in the Middle East.
- **Regional Role:** Iran served as a stabilizing, secular force and maintained ties with Israel.
- **Monarchical Objectives:** Foreign policy was centralized around the Shah's ambitions for modernization and economic dominance.

Post-Revolutionary Foreign Policy (After 1979):

- **Anti-Imperialism & Independence:** Prioritized "Neither East nor West," cutting ties with the United States.
- **Exporting the Islamic Revolution:** Focus shifted to religiously driven mobilization and support for Shia militant groups.
- **The Palestinian Cause:** Severed relations with Israel, adopting a strong anti-Zionist stance.



- **practical politics:** Post-1988, balanced ideology with economic and state-centric interests, including ties with Russia and China.

Note: Emergence of The Axis of Resistance

The Axis of Resistance is an informal coalition uniting various non-state militant groups. Key members include:

- **Hezbollah:** Shia militant group in Lebanon.
- **The Houthis:** Zaydi Shia movement in Yemen.
- **Palestinian Factions:** Including Hamas and Palestinian Islamic Jihad.
- **Iraqi Militias:** Operating under the Popular Mobilization Forces umbrella.

III. Emergence of Proxy Warfare (1980s–2000s)

III.1. Lebanon and Hezbollah

Hezbollah is a militant group that emerged in South Lebanon during a consolidation of Shia militias as a rival to the older Amal Movement. Hezbollah played a significant role in the Lebanese civil war, opposing US forces in 1982–83 and opposing Amal and Syria during the 1985–88 War of the Camps.

The Amal Movement

The Amal Movement is a Lebanese political party and militia affiliated mainly with the Shia community of Lebanon. It was founded by Musa al-Sadr and Hussein el-Husseini in 1974 as the "Movement of the Deprived". The party has been led by Nabih Berri since 1980.

The Amal Movement gained attention from Shia outcry after the disappearance of Musa al-Sadr and saw a renewal in popularity after the 1978 South Lebanon conflict with Israel. The Iranian Revolution of 1979 also provided momentum for the party. The Amal Movement is the largest predominantly Shia party in parliament, having fourteen representatives to Hezbollah's thirteen. Amal has an alliance with Hezbollah.



US Marines searching for victims in Beirut eight days after an attack that killed 241 American service members on October 23, 1983.

III.2. Hamas

Hamas is a Palestinian Sunni Islamist militant and political organisation that has governed the Gaza Strip since 2007. Founded in 1987, the group's name is an Arabic acronym for the "Islamic Resistance Movement". Its overarching goal is the establishment of an independent Islamic state in historical Palestine, and it fundamentally rejects the existence of Israel.

Following the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Iran fundamentally pivoted its foreign policy to champion the Palestinian cause, which allowed Hamas to become a key element of the Axis of Resistance after it was formed. While this patronage provided Hamas with critical funding, weapons, and training, it also inextricably linked the Palestinian territories to broader regional proxy warfare.

III.3. The Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), also known domestically as Sepah or Pasdaran and internationally as Iranian Revolutionary Guards, is a multi-service primary force of the Iranian Armed Forces. It consists of five service branches: Ground Forces, Aerospace Force, Navy, Quds Force, and Basij. It is led by a commander-in-chief, who is appointed by and reports to the Supreme Leader of Iran.

Growth and deep establishment

After Khamenei became the leader of Iran upon Khomeini's death in 1989, the IRGC became increasingly entrenched. The organization remained largely absent from the public sphere during



the presidency of Ali Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani (1989–97), but it was encouraged to take on a substantial role in the economic development of postwar Iran. A turning point came in 1997 with the election of the President. Mohammad Khatami (1997–2005), whose popular reform agenda threatened to undermine the dominance of the IRGC and of conservative clerics like Khamenei.

III.4. Iranian regional influence in MENA countries

Iran is not typified as a country that leads invasions, but is rather an actor that takes advantage of the conditions of invaded countries. The cases of Iraq, Yemen, Syria and Lebanon provide evidence for this argument, as Iran's presence is manifest not only in their civilian bodies, but also in their security and intelligence apparatuses. This phenomenon has led the capitals of these countries to be ironically portrayed in the regional media as "Tehran's four Arab capitals".

Since the new president, Ebrahim Raisi, took up office in July 2021, Iran's foreign and security policy towards these theatres has changed little, as the nuclear programme, missile programme and assistance to armed non-state actors such as Hamas, Hezbollah, Kata'ib Hezbollah and the Houthis persist as the central factors in Iranian strategic defence thinking. In parallel to this exercise in dissuasion, however, the new Raisi administration has also pursued temporary détente mechanisms towards other regional neighbours, most notably the expansion of the so-called "resistance economy" in Iraq, the easing of tensions with selected countries on the Arabian Peninsula, and its apparent consolidation in the Mediterranean, not only via countries such as Lebanon, Syria and Palestine, but also through contacts with the Algerian government. Taken together, these events represent a range of opportunities for the "revolutionary pragmatism" being pushed by the new Raisi Administration, whose priority, in the aftermath of the Covid-19 pandemic and in the midst of the Russian-Ukrainian conflict, is the achievement of a domestic economic recovery not dependent on the lifting of sanctions surrounding the complicated nuclear affair.

III.5. Asymmetric Warfare between the countries

Asymmetric warfare is a military conflict between opposing sides with vastly unequal power, resources, or tactics. The weaker or less traditional force avoids direct confrontation, relying instead on unconventional strategies—such as guerrilla tactics, cyberattacks, terrorism, or insurgencies—to exploit the stronger side's vulnerabilities. In this case both sides have used equally asymmetric tactics many times.

The ongoing war involving Iran, the United States, and Israel in 2026 can be interpreted as a complex interstate conflict set within a wider pattern of regional competition, nuclear tensions, and asymmetric warfare dynamics. Rather than constituting an isolated confrontation, the war reflects an increase of long-standing geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, generating wide-ranging humanitarian, economic, infrastructural, political, and environmental consequences.



The military balance within this conflict is characterized by a pronounced asymmetry. The United States and Israel possess significant advantages in terms of conventional military capabilities, including advanced airpower, intelligence systems, and precision-strike technologies. In contrast, Iran has developed an asymmetric warfare doctrine intended to mitigate these disadvantages.

The conflict demonstrates key features of hybrid warfare, combining direct interstate confrontation with proxy engagements, cyber operations, and economic coercion. Iranian-aligned groups operating across the Middle East and extending in some cases toward the Red Sea and parts of Eastern Africa, have contributed to broadening the geographical scope of the conflict. This expansion complicates the strategic environment for both the United States and Israel, increasing the likelihood of miscalculation and unintended escalation.

IV. Nuclear Tensions and the Shadow War (2000s–2018)

IV.1. Natanz Revelations

The Natanz revelation refers to the shocking press conference on August 14, 2002, in Washington, D.C. An Iranian opposing group revealed Tehran's long-hidden nuclear weapons program. Led by Alireza Jafarzadeh from the National Council of Resistance of Iran (NCRI), this announcement changed global politics and brought attention to infrastructure that remains a source of international conflict.

The Core Disclosures:

The NCRI shared detailed, intelligence-quality information gathered by an internal resistance network:

1. Located about 300 kilometers south of Tehran, this secret facility was being constructed under the guise of a "desert eradication project" to evade detection. The leak described two large underground halls that each measured 25,000 square meters, buried deep enough to resist air attacks.
2. The group also revealed a heavy-water production facility in Arak that could produce plutonium, giving Iran a second route to a nuclear bomb.

Before the press conference, these multi-million dollar industrial sites were completely unmonitored and hidden from the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA).

IV.2. IAEA Involvement

The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) is an intergovernmental organization that seeks to promote the peaceful use of nuclear energy and to inhibit its use for any military purpose, including nuclear weapons. It was established in 1957 as an autonomous organization within the United Nations system; though governed by its own founding treaty, the organization



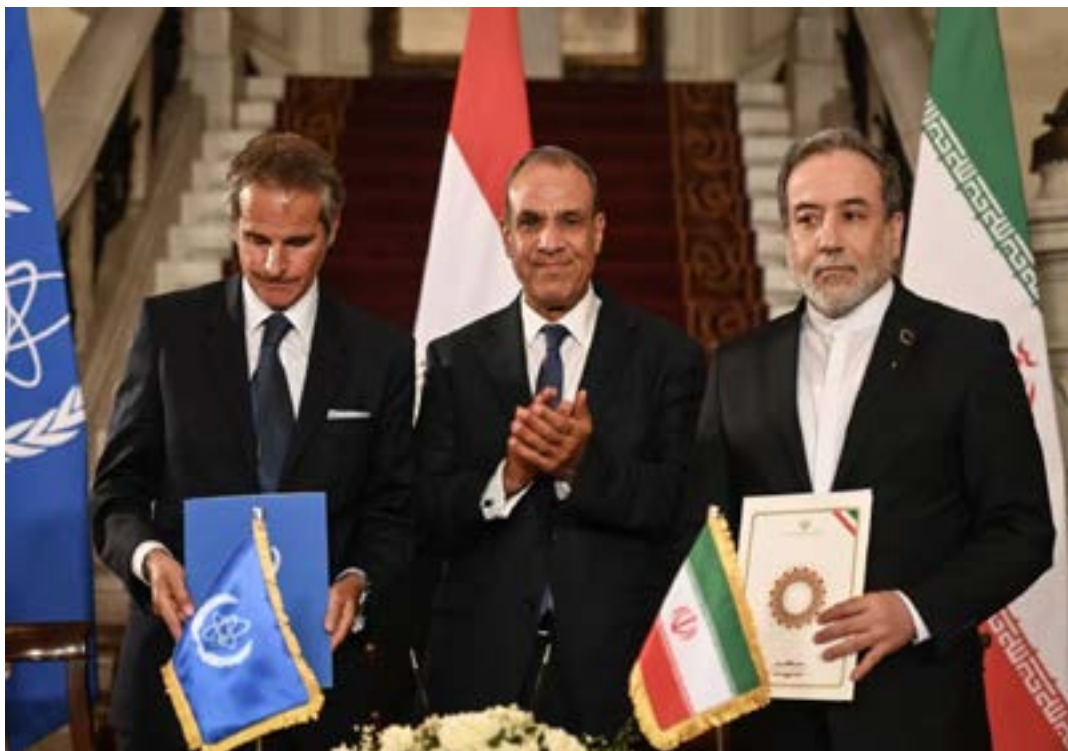
reports to both the General Assembly and the Security Council of the United Nations, and is headquartered at the UN Office at Vienna, Austria. Iran is a member of the IAEA and here are the major interactions between the two bodies:

1. **16 September 2002. Iran Statement to IAEA General Conference.** Mr Reza Aghazadeh, Vice-President of Iran and President of the Atomic Energy Organization of Iran, addressed the country's nuclear programme in a statement to the IAEA General Conference.
2. **22 February 2003. IAEA Director General Visits Iran for Talks on Nuclear Programme.** IAEA Director General Mohamed ElBaradei held talks with President Khatami and senior Iranian officials on the country's nuclear programme.
3. **18 December 2003. Iran Signs Additional Protocol on Nuclear Safeguards.** IAEA Director General Mohamed ElBaradei and Ambassador Salehi of Iran signed an Additional Protocol to Iran's NPT safeguards agreement, granting Agency inspectors greater authority in verifying the country's nuclear programme.
4. **24 September 2005. IAEA Board Adopts Resolution on Iran.** The IAEA Board of Governors adopted a resolution on the implementation of safeguards in the Islamic Republic of Iran. The resolution finds that Iran's failures and breaches constitute non-compliance and calls on Iran to return to the negotiating process.
5. **23 December 2006. UN Security Council Resolution on Iran.** The Security Council imposed sanctions on Iran, "blocking the import or export of sensitive nuclear material and equipment and freezing the financial assets of persons or entities supporting its proliferation sensitive nuclear activities". The resolution calls for IAEA Director General ElBaradei to report within 60 days "on whether Iran had established full and sustained suspension of all activities mentioned in the resolution, as well as on the process of Iranian compliance with all steps required by the IAEA Board."
6. **3 March 2008. UN Security Council Resolution on Iran.** The UN Security Council has imposed a third round of sanctions against Iran over its nuclear programme citing concerns of "the proliferation risks presented by the Iranian nuclear programme." The resolution calls for IAEA Director General Mohamed ElBaradei to report within 90 days on whether Iran has fully suspended uranium enrichment activities, in line with a previous Council demand.
7. **24 November 2013. Statement by IAEA Director General on Geneva Agreement.** IAEA Director General Yukiya Amano stated after an agreement was reached between the "P5+1" countries and Iran on a joint action plan.
8. **14 July 2015. Director General's Statement and Road-map for the Clarification of Past and Present Outstanding Issues regarding Iran's Nuclear Program.** IAEA Director General Yukiya Amano and Vice President of the Islamic Republic of Iran Ali Akhbar Salehi sign a roadmap for the clarification of past and present issues regarding Iran's nuclear program in Vienna.
9. **16 January 2016. IAEA Director General's Statement on Iran.** IAEA Director General Yukiva Amano delivered a statement confirming that Iran had completed the



necessary preparatory steps to start the implementation of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action.

10. **13 June 2025. Statements on the Situation in Iran.** Early this morning, the IAEA was informed of the military operation launched by Israel, which includes attacks on nuclear facilities in the Islamic Republic of Iran.



09 September 2025, Egypt, Cairo: Director General of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) Rafael Grossi (L) and Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi (R), sign an agreement on practical modalities to resume nuclear inspections on the Iranian nuclear program, in presence of Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty (C) at Tahrir Palace in Cairo.

IV. Sanctions due to Nuclear Tensions

1. Initial Escalation (2006–2008)

- December 2006: Resolution 1737 bans nuclear technology transfer.
- March 2007: Resolution 1747 expands asset freeze and arms embargo.
- 2008: Resolutions 1803/1835 call for inspections of suspicious cargo.

2. Broadening of Sanctions (2010–2012)

- June 2010: Resolution 1929 targets oil, shipping, and banking.
- July 2010: CISADA restricts petroleum trade.
- 2011–2012: US legislation blocks transactions with the Central Bank of Iran.



3. The JCPOA Era and Relief (2015–2016)

- July 2015: Iran and the P5+1 sign the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), also known as the Iran Nuclear Deal. Iran agrees to strictly curb its nuclear enrichment limits in exchange for significant sanctions relief.
- January 2016: "Implementation Day" is announced. The UN Security Council formally passes Resolution 2231 endorsing the deal, and the US and EU lift their nuclear-related secondary sanctions on Iran.

4. US Maximum Pressure and Deal Collapse (2018–2021)

- May 2018: The US officially withdraws from the JCPOA, reinstating heavy unilateral sanctions by November 2018.
- 2019–2020: The US expands the "maximum pressure" campaign, blacklisting Iran's metals industry, the Central Bank of Iran, and threatening secondary sanctions on any nation purchasing Iranian oil.
- 2021: Iran begins to significantly reduce its compliance with the JCPOA, heavily restricting inspections by the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA).

5. Recent Escalations (2025–2026)

- Mid-2025: Following a blistering military conflict between Israel and Iran, European powers (the E3: France, Germany, and the UK) trigger the JCPOA's "snapback" mechanism, taking formal diplomatic steps to initiate the re-imposition of UN Security Council sanctions.
- Late 2025–2026: In the wake of open hostilities and suspected covert nuclear advancements, the US and its allies continue to enforce heavy financial restrictions, targeting not only Iran's nuclear-related supply chains but also entities accused of aiding the country's energy exports amid ongoing regional instability.

IV.4. JCPOA

During 2016, Iran continued to follow its Safeguards Agreement and the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) signed in Vienna on 14 July 2015. The agreement was made between Iran and the E3/EU+3 countries. The United Nations Security Council adopted Resolution 2231, supporting the JCPOA and ending earlier sanctions resolutions.

Under the JCPOA, Iran agreed to reduce its centrifuges, limit uranium enrichment to 3.67% U-235, and keep only 300 kg of enriched uranium. The Fordow facility was converted into a research centre, while the Arak heavy-water reactor was redesigned. Iran also agreed not to develop nuclear weapons and allowed stronger monitoring by the International Atomic Energy Agency



The IAEA monitored Iran's nuclear activities and confirmed in January 2016 that Iran had completed important commitments. These included reducing centrifuges, limiting enrichment, shipping out excess uranium, and allowing continuous monitoring.

The IAEA issued several reports in 2016 and stated that Iran was continuing to implement the nuclear-related provisions of the JCPOA. However, the Agency also said that evaluations regarding undeclared nuclear material and activities were still ongoing.

IV.5. Israeli Opposition

Israel began its nuclear weapons programme in 1958 with the construction of the Dimona nuclear facility in the Negev Desert. Experts believe that over time Israel developed around 100–200 nuclear warheads. However, Israel followed a policy of “nuclear uncertainty,” meaning it neither confirmed nor denied possessing nuclear weapons.

The United States strongly supported Israel during this period. Although American leaders such as President Kennedy were concerned about Israel's nuclear programme in the 1960s, the US later chose not to pressure Israel seriously. Israel also refused to sign the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), unlike many other countries.

Arab countries argue that Israel's nuclear weapons create insecurity in the region and encourage an arms race. Former IAEA Director General Mohamed ElBaradei also warned that Israel's refusal to join the NPT could push other countries in the region to seek nuclear capability.

Israel, however, says that its nuclear policy is necessary for national security. Israeli leaders argue that the country faces threats from neighbouring states and from Iran. Because of this, Israel believes nuclear deterrence is important for its survival.

IV.6. Key Assassinations

1. Massoud Ali-Mohammadi (Assassinated: 2010)

On 12 January 2010, at 07:58 am, a motorbike rigged with explosives and parked near his car exploded while he was leaving home in Gheytariyeh neighbourhood of northern Tehran, for university. The force of remote controlled explosion shattered the windows of residences around the scientist's home, and it was reported that two other people were also injured in the blast.

Iranian state media accused Israel and the US of responsibility, while the US State Department called the allegation “absurd”. Ynetnews stated that “there is no known connection between his participation” in the SESAME, an international synchrotron-radiation facility located in Jordan, and the assassination. According to US intelligence sources, Israel is running a secret war against Iran, among techniques used are the killing of important persons in the Iranian atomic energy program.



2. Majid Shahriari (Assassinated: 2010)

On 29 November 2010, assassins riding motorcycles planted and detonated an explosive device using C-4 on his car door whilst he was driving. He was instantly killed. His fellow nuclear scientist, Fereydoon Abbasi, a professor at Shahid Beheshti University, was severely wounded. Dr Abbasi's wife was also hurt. The killers had attached bombs to the professors' cars and detonated them from a distance.

3. Dariush Rezaeinejad (Assassinated: 2011)

Rezaeinejad was targeted on July 23, 2011, along with his wife and daughter, in front of his house and in his car while they were entering the house. Five bullets were fired at him, one bullet hit his neck, and the other hit his hand. According to his wife, Shohreh Pirani, Mohsen Fakhrizadeh, another nuclear physicist, was also present when the injured Rezaeinejad entered the hospital.

IV.7. Stuxnet

Although not an assassination, this is impossible to separate from the killings. The cyberweapon Stuxnet, widely attributed to Israel and the U.S., targeted Iranian centrifuges at Natanz. The cyberweapon Stuxnet, widely attributed to Israel and the U.S., targeted Iranian centrifuges at Natanz.

Stuxnet is a malicious computer worm first uncovered on 17 June 2010 and thought to have been in development since at least 2005. Stuxnet targets supervisory control and data acquisition (SCADA) systems and is believed to be responsible for causing substantial damage to the Iran nuclear program after it was first installed on a computer at the Natanz Nuclear Facility in 2009. Although neither the United States nor Israel has openly admitted responsibility, multiple independent news organizations claim Stuxnet to be a cyberweapon built jointly by the two countries in a collaborative effort known as Operation Olympic Games. The program, started during the Bush administration, was rapidly expanded within the first months of Barack Obama's presidency.

Stuxnet specifically targets programmable logic controllers (PLCs), which allow the automation of electromechanical processes such as those used to control machinery and industrial processes including gas centrifuges for separating nuclear material. Exploiting four zero-day flaws in the systems, Stuxnet functions by targeting machines using the Microsoft Windows operating system and networks, then seeking out Siemens Step7 software.



Country Stance and Political Developments

United States of America

Since the 1960s, the relationship between Israel and the United States has grown into a close alliance in economic, strategic and military aspects. The U.S. has provided strong support for Israel; it has played a key role in the promotion of good relations between Israel and its neighbouring Arab states. In turn, Israel provides a strategic American foothold in the region as well as intelligence and advanced technological partnerships.

As a result of the **Iranian takeover of the American Embassy** on November 4, 1979, the United States and Iran severed diplomatic relations in April 1980. The United States and the Islamic Republic of Iran have had no formal diplomatic relationship since that date.

The U.S. military **heavily intervenes in the Iran-Israel conflict** to stop a massive regional war. American troops, warships, and fighter jets are stationed across the Middle East to act as a shield. When Iran attacks Israel, U.S. forces immediately shoot down the incoming missiles and drones. The U.S. also shares top-secret intelligence with Israel, guards vital oil shipping routes, and protects its own military bases from regional rebel groups.

The U.S. government expanded the sanctions put on Iran in the year 2025 in response to Iran's nuclear program and its support for groups designated by the United States as terrorist organizations, including Hezbollah, Hamas, and Palestine Islamic Jihad.

A ceasefire between Iran and Israel took effect on **24 June 2025**, ending the Twelve-Day War. It was mediated by the United States and Qatar. The exchange of fire ended the next morning, marking the beginning of the ceasefire.

The United States has played a major role in the Iran-Israel conflict, standing firmly with Israel. The United States has also made numerous other efforts to possibly de-escalate the military conflict and has continuously been a part of peace talks.

The Russian Federation

The Iranian–Russian Treaty on Comprehensive Strategic Partnership is a strategic partnership agreement signed on **17 January 2025**, by Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian. The treaty aims to improve ties between the two nations, through expanding economic cooperation, mitigating the impact of US sanctions, and strengthening military and political partnership.

Current **Russia-Israel relations are at their lowest point** in recent history, defined by escalating diplomatic friction. While communication channels remain open to manage security, Russia's



deepening strategic and military alliance with Iran rooted in the Ukraine conflict and its growing criticism of Israeli military operations have severely strained historical ties

Russia's security interests in the Middle East revolve around a practical balancing act. It relies on a tactical defense partnership with Iran to counter Western influence, while concurrently maintaining crucial de-confliction and security ties with Israel to protect its economic and military footprint in Syria.

Russia strongly opposes US and Israeli military intervention in Iran. It publicly condemns the operations as "unprovoked acts of armed aggression" and violations of international law, though Moscow's response is largely rhetorical and strategic, **deliberately avoiding direct military confrontation** to prevent being drawn into a second high-intensity conflict.

Russia, too, is playing a role like the United States to mediate the de-escalation of the conflict, with the Russian President Vladimir Putin and Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov having held multiple high-level meetings with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in Moscow to maintain de-escalation.

French Republic

France firmly **opposes Iran acquiring nuclear weapons**, viewing Tehran's nuclear ambitions as a direct threat to global security. Together with the UK and Germany (the E3), France champions a negotiated, diplomatic solution, and condemns both regional violence and the Iranian regime's internal human rights abuses.

France is actively pursuing de-escalation by rejecting military-only solutions in favor of a comprehensive peace strategy. Key diplomatic moves include pushing for ceasefires across the broader Middle East, launching UN frameworks to secure maritime navigation, and coordinating with international partners to contain regional proxy warfare.

French President Emmanuel Macron and Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot are holding intensive talks with global and regional partners including a joint de-escalation framework with China's Foreign Ministry to seek political solutions over military actions.

The United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland

Iran-UK relations are deeply strained, characterized by the UK's alignment with U.S. policies in the Middle East. Tensions center on Iran's nuclear program, regional conflicts, and the UK's counter-terrorism operations against Iranian-backed groups on British soil. Bilateral ties remain persistently volatile, though formal diplomatic communication is maintained.

Israel–United Kingdom relations, or Anglo-Israeli relations, are the diplomatic and commercial ties between the United Kingdom and Israel. The British embassy to Israel is located in Tel Aviv.



The UK has an honorary consul in Eilat and a non-accredited consulate-general in Jerusalem, that represents the United Kingdom in that city and the Palestinian territories.

The People's Republic of China

Iran and China have maintained diplomatic ties through the **Iran–China 25-year Cooperation Program** or Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. It is a 25-year cooperation agreement on the further development of Iran–China relations signed in Tehran by the Chinese and Iranian foreign ministers on 27 March 2021 the final details of the agreement have yet to be officially announced.

China is Israel's second largest trading partner globally and its largest trading partner in East Asia. Bilateral trade volume increased from **\$50 million in 1992** to over **\$10 billion in 2013**. Israel has traded significantly with China in technology and arms. The relations between the two countries have been complicated by China's support for the Palestinians and Iran, both involved in ongoing conflicts with Israel, and the geopolitical rivalry between China and the United States, Israel's primary security guarantor.

China firmly opposes Western military intervention in the Iran-Israel conflict, condemning unilateral strikes as violations of international law and the UN Charter. Beijing argues that the use of force exacerbates regional tensions, and has positioned itself as a diplomatic mediator rather than a direct military participant. China also firmly opposes the fact that Western military is intervening in the Iran-Israel conflict, condemning unilateral strikes as violations of international law and the UN Charter.

Alongside this, Beijing argues that the use of force exacerbates regional tensions, and has positioned itself as a diplomatic mediator rather than a direct military participant.

Islamic Republic of Iran

Iran's strategic doctrine is built on "forward defense" and asymmetric deterrence, projecting power to secure its borders through regional alliances and missile capabilities without direct confrontation. Its regional influence relies on the "Axis of Resistance," a network of non-state actors extending Tehran's influence across the Middle East.

Stemming from Iran's strategic loneliness and vulnerability, a policy called Forward Defence aims to fight adversaries outside Iranian territory. It is implemented by arming, training, and financing hybrid military and political actors across the region. Lacking conventional military parity with global powers, Iran uses asymmetric warfare by relying on a massive stockpile of ballistic and cruise missiles, drones, and naval capabilities designed to disrupt shipping.

Iran has faced severe strain and pressure on its traditional proxy network and is undergoing strategic adaptation. There is a noted internal shift in focus toward calculated defiance, diplomacy, and strengthening "strategic brotherhoods" (such as with Iraq) to withstand Western



pressure. Moving beyond basic military posturing, Iran has placed greater weight on technological independence, digital security, and strong supply chains in its compound security and deterrence strategy.

Iran officially ended the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), declaring all nuclear restrictions void. In ongoing 2026 negotiations, the U.S. has agreed to conditionally suspend oil export sanctions. However, significant deadlock remains, as Tehran rejects demands to surrender its enriched uranium stockpile and halt enrichment. Since the collapse of the JCPOA, Iran has drastically increased its uranium enrichment capabilities, including trace amounts nearing weapons-grade levels.

The Strait of Hormuz has been heavily disrupted by the ongoing military conflict that began in early 2026. Iran has established a newly formed Persian Gulf Strait Authority (PGSA) to regulate transit, and the nation plans to offer maritime insurance to transiting ships payable in cryptocurrency. While some strategic exemptions are being made for specific friendly nations, such as safe passage for India-flagged crude oil tankers, the broader blockade on Western-linked traffic has choked global energy pipelines.

Because the Strait facilitates the export of massive daily volumes of crude oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG), its restriction has severely strained global energy markets. The military actions and blockades have removed millions of barrels of oil from the daily global supply, driving up shipping insurance premiums and energy price benchmarks. Asian economies, including India, are heavily dependent on the Gulf for their petroleum and LNG imports, leaving them exceptionally exposed to supply constraints and price volatility.

State of Israel

Israel's national security doctrine is historically built on three core pillars: *deterrence* (discouraging adversaries from attacking), *early warning* (detecting threats before they materialize), and *decisive victory* (ending conflicts swiftly by moving the battle into enemy territory).

Apart from these three core pillars there are also other policies which further contribute to Israel's national security doctrine. Self-Reliance refers to the principle that Israel must be capable of defending itself by itself, without relying on foreign troops on its soil, though backed by strong strategic alliances.. Alongside Self-Reliance, due to a historical lack of geographic depth and demographic size, Israel has also added a fourth pillar/policy in the 21st century: active defense (e.g., the Iron Dome missile shield).

Apart from the USA, Israel has many other western allies in Europe and many other places. Israel maintains strong bilateral ties with major European powers, particularly the United Kingdom, France, and Germany. European nations are significant trading partners and closely



cooperate on counter-terrorism and regional diplomacy. While European governments consistently recognize Israel's right to self-defense and support its security, relations with some Western allies face friction over the broader Middle East conflicts, humanitarian concerns, and disputes over the status of Palestinian territories. Despite localized diplomatic tensions, Israel's deep integration with the West is based on shared democratic values, economic interconnectedness, and mutual security interests.

Israel's counter-terrorism and regional security strategy integrates multi-layered defense, deterrence, intelligence dominance, and strategic diplomacy. Driven by immediate and survival based threats, this multifaceted approach is executed through several core pillars to protect the state and its citizens:

Lebanese Republic

Hezbollah has opened a dangerous second front in the Israeli-Palestinian war of attrition that began in September 2000. The attached analysis not only describes the nature of Hezbollah and its military capabilities, but the severe limits to the Lebanese Army and other divisions and problems within Lebanon.

It is important to note that the dangers involved do not simply extend to Hezbollah actions. Hezbollah probably saw this as an opportunity to try to demonstrate that it still is a key fighter in the Arab cause. It had worked out agreements with Lebanon's Christians who recognized that it was the one militia that could keep its arms, and that the Lebanese Army would remain largely passive in south Lebanon. Ideology, politics, opportunism, and anger may all have been factors, although with the fact that Israel had made massive prisoner releases the last time Hezbollah took hostages and once again had appeared to be "defeated."

Latent in this term was the sense that Iran had succeeded in establishing its presence on the Mediterranean coast, and that for the first time this presence sparked an all-out war in which an organization, inspired by Iran and armed with Iranian weapons, fought against Israel. The Iranian presence in Lebanon, Iran's major influence and perhaps even control over Hizbollah, and its ability to motivate the organization to act in its name and under its auspices are a known reality.

Iran subsequently became Hizbollah's main source of economic, military, and political support. Iranian aid to the organization included the dispatch of Iranian volunteers, some 2,500 members of the Revolutionary Guards, who arrived in Lebanon in 1982. Iran-Hizbollah communication, including Iran's aid to the organization, is conducted through the al-Quds Force, an elite unit that is part of the Revolutionary Guards.



Syrian Arab Republic

The Russian intervention in September 2015 provided decisive air power to Syrian and Iranian-backed ground forces, expanding Bashar al-Assad's territorial control and solidifying the regime's hold on power through parallel diplomatic efforts. However, throughout the course of the Syrian Civil War, regularized military and political exchanges strengthened the Russia-Iran relationship while contributing to greater coherence between Moscow and Tehran on the limits and parameters of cooperation.

Although Russia and Iran have converged around the overarching objective of strengthening the Assad regime, Moscow and Tehran's engagement in Syria illustrates a complex mosaic of overlapping interests, broader regional entanglements, and contending approaches to post-war reconstruction.

Following the fall of the Assad regime on 8 December 2024, Israel invaded the demilitarized buffer zone in southwestern Syria (adjacent to the Israeli-occupied Golan Heights) and has continued to occupy it. Israel also carried out an airstrike campaign to cripple the Syrian Armed Forces, and demanded that it stay out of southern Syria. Israel's government said these actions were intended to prevent any "potential threat" from post-war Syria.

Israel took advantage of the power vacuum created by the fall of former Syrian president Bashar al-Assad to increase the amount of territory it controlled by several hundred square miles. Israel declared the 1974 Agreement on Disengagement with Ba'athist Syria to be void. Israel initially said this new invasion would be "temporary", but later said it would hold onto the territory for an "unlimited time".

Syria faces a fragile transitional landscape marked by severe internal security fragmentation and dangerous regional spread. Following the sudden fall of the Bashar al-Assad regime, the interim government led by President Ahmad al-Sharaa is struggling to shift from political survival to united governance. Clashing military factions, acute economic collapse, and ongoing proxy elements are intersecting to create a volatile climate inside Syria that constantly threatens the stability of its Mediterranean and Middle Eastern neighbours.

Kingdom of Saudi Arabia

Iran and Saudi Arabia are engaged in a proxy war over influence in the Middle East and other regions of the Muslim world. The two countries have provided varying degrees of support to opposing sides in nearby conflicts, including the civil wars in Syria and Yemen; and disputes in Bahrain, Lebanon, Qatar, and Iraq. The struggle also extends to disputes or broader competition in other countries globally including in West, North and East Africa, South, Central, Southeast Asia, the Balkans, and the Caucasus.



The State of Israel and the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia have never had formal diplomatic relations. Unofficial Bilateral negotiations on Israeli–Saudi normalization began in 2023, with the United States serving as the mediator

During the main phase of the Arab–Israeli conflict, Saudi Arabia supported the Arab League against Israel. Likewise, the official Saudi policy towards the Israeli–Palestinian conflict has been supportive of the Palestinian Arabs. However, reports have surfaced in recent years indicating extensive behind-the-scenes cooperation in the areas of diplomacy, intelligence, and security.

Saudi Arabia has pivoted toward diplomatic engagement to protect its own economic and security interests. Having restored diplomatic ties with Tehran, Riyadh prefers a model of regional de-escalation over the hardline, confrontational approach pursued by Washington and Jerusalem. Saudi officials even reportedly acted as a back-channel, warning Tehran to reach an agreement with the U.S. to avoid a devastating escalation with Israel.

Republic of India

India and Israel maintain a close and multifaceted bilateral relationship, underpinned by strategic interests, and a history of cooperation across various sectors. Over the years, Israel has emerged as one of India's key partners in areas such as defense, agriculture, science and technology, and counter-terrorism. The partnership is characterized by high-level political engagement, increasing economic ties, and collaboration in innovation and security, reflecting a steady deepening of ties between the two countries.

The Republic of India and the Islamic Republic of Iran maintain a bilateral relationship. Independent India and Iran established diplomatic relations on 15 March 1950. From a geopolitical perspective, despite the two countries having some common strategic interests, India and Iran differ significantly on key foreign policy issues. India has expressed strong opposition to Iran's nuclear program and while both nations continue to oppose the Taliban, India supported the presence of NATO-led forces in Afghanistan, unlike Iran. India has also consistently voiced stronger support for Israel than for Iran in the 2020s. Due to the long history of geopolitical conflict between the two regions, including imperialism, and the cultural and religious differences between both communities, Iran is often a target for the Hindu right wing. Conversely, India is often accused by Iran of engaging in Islamophobia and racism.

Amidst the Middle Eastern conflict, India maintains a fairly neutral stance carefully balancing deep defense ties with Israel against critical energy and economic partnerships with Iran and the Gulf States.

Federal Republic of Germany

Germany–Israel relations are the diplomatic relationship between the Federal Republic of



Germany and the State of Israel. After the end of World War II and the Holocaust, relations gradually thawed as West Germany offered to pay reparations to Israel in 1952 and diplomatic relations were officially established in 1965. Today, Israel and Germany maintain a "special relationship" based on shared beliefs and a combination of historical perspectives. A central pillar of this relationship is Germany's commitment to Israel's security as part of its Staatsräson (reason of state), a policy that has also sparked domestic and international debate regarding its political and legal implications.

Official diplomatic relations between Iran and Germany after World War II began in 1952, when Iran opened its first diplomatic mission office in Bonn. Both countries' predecessor states had maintained formal diplomatic relations since the end of the 19th century. Germany has an embassy in Tehran, which was originally established in the court of Naser al-Din Shah Qajar in October 1884 and has been in the present building since 1894. Iran opened its embassy in Berlin in 1885.

Germany's approach to the Middle East combines hundreds of millions in humanitarian funding with diplomatic efforts focused on de-escalation. Berlin partners with the UN and international agencies to provide life-saving food, shelter, and medical care, while also leveraging diplomatic talks to contain regional conflicts and push for ceasefires.

Republic of Iraq

The Popular Mobilization Forces, also known as the Popular Mobilization Units (PMU), is an Iranian-backed paramilitary umbrella group that operates within Iraq. Although formally and legally part of the Iraqi Armed Forces and reporting directly to the prime minister, PMF leaders act independently from state control, and in practice, answer to the supreme leader of Iran.

To try to suppress the Iraqi militia effort, U.S. and Israeli airstrikes have retaliated against Iraqi militia targets in eight Iraqi provinces, killing nearly 100 militia fighters, as well as some regular Iraqi forces that are co-located with militia units. The Gulf states have issued unprecedented public and joint condemnations, summoned Iraqi diplomats, and warned Baghdad of potential economic and diplomatic penalties if it fails to prevent militia attacks from Iraqi territory.

Baghdad's failure to keep all its constituencies and factions out of the war has damaged Iraq's economy, harmed the population, and set back longstanding efforts by Iraqi leaders to establish the government as the sole source of sanctioned armed force within Iraq's borders. Even though the Iran-aligned militias have drawn Iraq into the U.S.-Iran conflict, the war has given the militias additional domestic support — at least while the war remains unsettled — for resisting efforts by outgoing Prime Minister Mohammad Shia al-Sudani to disarm and demobilize them.

Japan

The rapidly escalating conflict in the Middle East has triggered renewed volatility in global



energy markets and exposed the structural vulnerabilities of oil and gas importers. Following U.S. strikes on Iran on 28 February and the temporary closure of the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most critical maritime energy chokepoints, oil and gas supplies from the Persian Gulf have been halted and global energy prices have soared.

For Japan, the implications are immediate. The country remains one of the most energy import-dependent major economies in the world, importing around 87% of its energy supply in 2024. Approximately 90% of its crude oil and 11% of its liquefied natural gas (LNG) comes from the Middle East, with a large share transiting through the Strait of Hormuz.

Japan maintains diplomatic relations with every United Nations member nation except for North Korea, in addition to UN observer states Holy See, as well as Kosovo, Cook Islands, and Niue. In a multipolar world, Japan and the GCC should develop strategic ties that move beyond the traditional oil-for-technology framework.

Arab Republic of Egypt

Egypt's relations with both Iran and Israel remain complex and strategically important in the Middle East. Relations between Egypt and Iran have historically been strained since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, particularly due to Egypt's peace treaty with Israel, its close ties with the United States, and differing regional interests. However, recent years have witnessed gradual diplomatic thawing. In 2023, following the Chinese-brokered Saudi-Iran rapprochement, Egypt and Iran conducted several rounds of talks in Oman aimed at restoring diplomatic relations.

Relations between Egypt and Israel are formally stable under the 1979 Egypt-Israel Peace Treaty, which made Egypt the first Arab country to officially recognize Israel. Although the relationship is often described as a "cold peace," security and energy cooperation between the two states has continued, especially regarding Gaza border management and regional counterterrorism efforts. Egypt has also played a major mediating role in negotiations involving Israel and Palestinian factions.

United Arab Emirates

Israel and the United Arab Emirates formally agreed in August 2020 to establish diplomatic relations in a United States-brokered deal that also requires Israel to halt its plan to annex parts of the West Bank, including the Jordan Valley. Since establishing an official relationship in 2020, the relationship between Israel and UAE was strongly reinforced with public diplomacy, numerous signed agreements including reciprocal visa free travel in 2020 and free trade agreement in 2022, as well as expanded tourism and trade relationship. After 49 years, Israel and the United Arab Emirates fully normalized their diplomatic relations and began cooperation across tourism, education, healthcare, trade, and security.

In late July 2019, an Emirati delegation of coast guard commanders met with their Iranian



counterparts in Tehran for the first time in six years in order to improve maritime cooperation in the Strait of Hormuz. The UAE aims to position itself as an interlocutor with Iran and to reshape the mechanisms regulating the region's geopolitical architecture to support de-escalation, de-confliction and economic diversification. However, outstanding conflicts remain regarding the sovereignty dispute over the islands of Abu Musa and the Greater and Lesser Tunbs in the Persian Gulf

The UAE aims to position itself as an interlocutor with Iran and to reshape the mechanisms regulating the region's geopolitical architecture to support de-escalation, de-confliction and economic diversification. In late July 2019, an Emirati delegation of coast guard commanders have met with their Iranian counterparts in Tehran for the first time in six years, in order to improve maritime co-operation in the Strait of Hormuz. The UAE and Iran share close economic ties, with Dubai in particular serving as an important commercial hub for Iran.

Republic of South Africa

South Africa's foreign policy is anchored in constitutional values and active non-alignment, avoiding bloc allegiance in a multipolar world. The nation pursues strategic independence by engaging all international partners and advocating for a rules-based, inclusive global order governed strictly by international law.

A wider Middle East conflict could intensify competition for influence in Africa, especially with the United States, Gulf states, China, Russia, Iran, and Türkiye. South Africa's position on the Middle East conflict prioritizes immediate ceasefires, multilateral diplomacy, and strict adherence to international law. The country strongly opposes unilateral military actions and has actively pursued mediation efforts to resolve the escalating tensions and conflicts in the region.

Italian Republic

Italy is a founding member of NATO and continues to play a significant role in Mediterranean security, maritime stability, and regional defense cooperation. Italy maintains close diplomatic, economic, and security relations with Israel while simultaneously expanding cooperation with Gulf States, particularly in the areas of energy security, trade, infrastructure, and regional stability. Italy has supported dialogue and diplomatic engagement with Middle Eastern states while balancing its strategic partnerships across the region. Rome has also expressed concern regarding regional escalation and threats to maritime trade routes and global energy supplies resulting from instability in the Middle East.

Italy has consistently supported humanitarian assistance, ceasefire negotiations, and diplomatic initiatives aimed at reducing tensions and protecting civilians affected by conflict. The Italian government has repeatedly emphasized the importance of international law, humanitarian access, and multilateral diplomacy in addressing regional crises. Italy continues to support peacebuilding efforts, humanitarian aid operations, and international cooperation through the United Nations



and European institutions in order to promote long-term stability and de-escalation in the region.

Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela

Iran–Venezuela relations, having strengthened in recent years, were regarded as "friendly", according to former Iranian President Hassan Rouhani. The two countries are contemporary strategic allies of the Russian Federation and the People's Republic of China while opposing U.S. hegemony in their respective regions.

Venezuela's official foreign policy position has long been rooted in anti-domination, opposition to U.S. influence, and solidarity with states challenging Western dominance. "Venezuela's foreign policy has been shaped by Hugo Chavez's strategy of domestic and international polarisation," and continues to be driven by opposition to "U.S. imperialism." Caracas has consistently promoted alliances with countries questioning American leadership, particularly Iran, Russia, Cuba, and Syria.

Venezuela has repeatedly condemned U.S. and Israeli military actions in the Middle East, especially operations targeting Iran. The government views such actions as violations of sovereignty and international law while strongly supporting Iran as a strategic partner. Despite this alliance, Venezuela has also criticized retaliatory attacks that risk wider regional escalation, instead calling for diplomacy and de-escalation. Since the Hugo Chávez era, Venezuela has pursued "anti-hegemonic" partnerships with U.S. adversaries as part of a broader effort to counter Western influence and maintain strategic autonomy.

Federative Republic of Brazil

The importance of the global South continues to gain prominence in a changing geopolitical landscape. As an important member of the Global South, Brazil's diplomatic strategy and great power identity shaping have become the focus of research. Given its deep knowledge of the international power structure and precise positioning of its own interests and economic and geopolitical considerations, Brazil has shaped its great power identity through active participation in regional integration, multilateral diplomacy, and positive neutrality strategies.

Brazil, under President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, has taken a strong diplomatic stance against the joint U.S.–Israeli strikes on Iran. Instead of supporting military escalation, Brasília has repeatedly called for calm, dialogue, and respect for international law. The Brazilian government described the attacks as violations of Iranian sovereignty and warned that continued escalation could destabilize not just the Middle East, but global peace and security as well.

Lula's government believes that negotiations and multilateral diplomacy are the only realistic path toward peace. Brazil has consistently pushed for de-escalation, humanitarian protection, and greater involvement of international institutions like the United Nations in resolving the crisis. This position also reflects Brazil's broader Global South foreign policy, which emphasizes



sovereignty, non-intervention, and resistance to unilateral military action by major powers.

Sultanate of Oman

Oman has remained neutral and facilitated economic transactions between Qatar and other GCC countries. The Sultanate has used its balanced relationships with all of the major parties both within and outside Yemen to work towards resolving the Yemen conflict. While managing these delicate diplomatic tensions, Oman has also led working groups in China and India on bilateral economic ties as well as maintained cordial relations with Iran.

Oman has developed close ties to its neighbours; it joined the six-member Gulf Cooperation Council when it was established in 1980. Oman maintains good relations with Iran, its north-eastern neighbor across the Gulf of Oman, and the two countries regularly exchange delegations. Oman is an active member in international and regional organizations, notably the Arab League and the Gulf Cooperation Council.

Oman plays a uniquely crucial role in the Strait of Hormuz maritime security, as the primary shipping lanes fall within Omani territorial waters. Oman maintains strict neutrality and works alongside international bodies and Iran to preserve safe navigation and coordinate responses to regional tensions.

Republic of Turkey

The Islamic Republic of Iran and the Republic of Turkey maintain bilateral relations. The two states have a complex relationship, by competing over influence in Syria and the Caucasus through supporting opposing proxies as part of a proxy conflict. However, both countries also have some shared interests, as both are trade and economic partners. Their relationship is centuries old, dating to the 16th century when Sunni Ottoman Empire and the Shia Safavid empire fought each other for centuries.

The State of Israel and Turkey formally established diplomatic relations in March 1949. Less than a year after the Israeli Declaration of Independence, Turkey recognized Israeli sovereignty, making it the world's first Muslim-majority country to do so. Both countries gave high priority to bilateral cooperation in the areas of diplomacy and military/strategic ties, while sharing concerns with respect to the regional instabilities in the Middle East.

In recent decades, particularly under Turkey's Erdoğan administration, the two countries' relationship with each other has deteriorated considerably. However, diplomatic ties were reinstated after a normalization initiative in mid-2022. Türkiye has been exerting every effort to further enhance and diversify the already excellent relations with the State of Palestine in many fields. Bilateral relations with Palestine are comprehensively addressed through high-level mutual visits and meetings of the Joint Committee established between the two countries.



Turkey's strategic influence in the Middle East is anchored in its formidable military power, expansive drone diplomacy, and geopolitical balancing act between Western allies and Eastern powers. Seeking greater regional autonomy, Ankara frequently acts as an independent agenda-setter to project its interests.

Republic of Yemen

The State of Israel and the Republic of Yemen do not have diplomatic relations. Since Israel's formal establishment in 1948, Yemen and its predecessors (the Kingdom of Yemen and the Yemen Arab Republic in the North, and South Yemen in the South) have repeatedly denounced Israel in the context of regional conflicts with Palestine and the wider Arab world. Since the Houthi insurgency in Yemen, direct strikes between the Houthis and Israel have taken place.

Ties between Iran and Yemen have largely been defined by the impact of the Iran–Saudi Arabia proxy conflict on the Yemeni political atmosphere. Since the Islamic Revolution in 1979, the Iranian government has been the strongest state supporter of Yemen's Houthis, which espouse Zaydi Shia Islam and comprise part of the Iran-led "Axis of Resistance" in the Middle East.

To date, Yemen's Ansar Allah, also known as the Houthis, have played a limited role in the U.S., Israel and Iran war. This cautious engagement raises important questions about their motives and the factors that could push this influential non-state actor to escalate further.

Despite possessing highly effective tools, the Houthis have opted for restraint over total engagement. Their behavior reflects a doctrine of limited escalation, rooted in military, economic, and strategic calculations, aimed at achieving certain political gains while avoiding a slide into full-scale confrontation. This strategy deploys their leverage within a carefully calibrated framework that balances influence against survival, while keeping some of their powder dry, most notably, their leverage over the Red Sea.

Ansar Allah's involvement in the conflict can be understood through two theoretical lenses. The first is asymmetric deterrence, whereby weaker actors use low-cost tools to achieve strategic impact. The second is asymmetric warfare, which explains how non-state actors engage adversaries that are superior in conventional terms. The Houthis' operational behavior can be further explained through the concept of sub-threshold escalation, by disassembling military and economic considerations and linking them to the regional context.

The escalating tension between Iran and Israel has added to Yemen's existing internal warfare and led to an acute humanitarian emergency as more than 22 million people, about half of the country's population, need aid. Houthis' bombardments of Israel and the Red Sea have been answered by vicious counterattacks destroying all vital facilities and causing acute food shortage.



Ukraine

Ukraine has maintained close relations with Western allies, particularly the United States and NATO members, since the beginning of the Russia–Ukraine conflict in 2014. Western countries have provided Ukraine with military aid, intelligence support, economic assistance, and diplomatic backing against Russian aggression. NATO has also expanded cooperation with Ukraine through joint exercises, security partnerships, and defense modernization programs, while supporting Ukraine’s sovereignty and territorial integrity.

At the same time, Ukraine’s relationship with NATO has remained a major source of tension with Russia. Ukraine has repeatedly expressed interest in joining NATO and integrating more closely with Western institutions, while Russia has viewed NATO expansion near its borders as a direct security threat. The conflict has therefore become central to broader geopolitical competition between Russia and the Western alliance.

One of the most immediate consequences is the diversion of American and allied attention and military aid away from Ukraine. For Ukraine, this redirection implies intensified competition for critical supplies: artillery shells, air-defense interceptors, and advanced systems needed to counter Russian ballistic and cruise missiles may well be rerouted to protect U.S. bases, Israeli population centers, or Gulf allies from Iranian retaliation.

A prolonged U.S.-Iran conflict would likely deepen this strain. Even the brief Israel-Iran exchanges demonstrated how quickly Middle Eastern priorities can overshadow support for Ukraine, temporarily delaying shipments of munitions and equipment. European allies, confronted with energy price shocks and economic pressure, could also scale back their assistance. Ukraine would then be forced into a more defensive stance, while Russia could exploit the moment to intensify attacks on infrastructure, railways, and power grids.

State of Libya

The Libyan crisis is the current humanitarian crisis and political-military instability occurring in Libya, beginning with the Arab Spring protests of 2011, which led to two civil wars, foreign military intervention, and the ousting and killing of Muammar Gaddafi. The first civil war’s aftermath and proliferation of armed groups led to violence and instability across the country, which erupted into renewed civil war in 2014. The second war lasted until October 23, 2020, when all parties agreed to a permanent ceasefire and negotiations.

Since March 2022, two different governments control the country, the Tripoli-based and internationally recognized Government of National Unity, which controls the western part of the country and is led by Abdul Hamid Dbeibeh, and the House of Representatives-recognized Government of National Stability, which nominally governs the central and eastern part of Libya and is led by Osama Hammad under the de facto rule of the Libyan National Army and its commander Khalifa Haftar.



Libya's stability has taken on renewed strategic importance as the impact of the United States and Israel's war with Iran reverberates through global energy markets, pushing Brent crude prices to a three-year high as of mid-March. Disruptions to shipping, heightened risk premiums, and constrained spare capacity have sharpened attention on every marginal barrel. In that environment, Libya's oil production, stable for now under informal arrangements but structurally fragile, matters more than usual. Sustaining existing Libyan production, and potentially increasing it, depends on a governing arrangement capable of keeping ports open, pipelines flowing, and revenues distributed without triggering conflict.

These dynamics are increasingly manifesting in heightened friction among Libya's diverse security actors. While large-scale conflict has not resumed, armed groups linked to state institutions are again jockeying for position, particularly around access to revenue streams, fuel distribution, and territorial control. In Libya's recent history, such patterns have often preceded more overt confrontation.

Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)

The Organisation of Islamic Cooperation, formerly the Organisation of the Islamic Conference, is an intergovernmental organisation founded in 1969. It consists of 57 member states, 48 of which are Muslim-majority. The organisation claims to be "the collective voice of the Muslim world" and works to "safeguard and protect the interests of the Muslim world in the spirit of promoting international peace and harmony".

OIC has permanent delegations to the United Nations and the European Union. Its official languages are Arabic, English, and French. It operates affiliated, specialised, and subsidiary organs within the framework of OIC Charter.

The Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) responds to the Middle East conflict through diplomatic advocacy, humanitarian aid coordination, and international legal mobilization. Using its OIC Media Observatory on Israeli Crimes Against Palestinians and Council of Foreign Ministers, the OIC condemns Israeli military actions and works to prevent forced displacement.

The Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) drives its Diplomatic and Humanitarian Initiative through the Department of Humanitarian Affairs (ICHAD). It partners globally with organizations like the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), UNDP, and ICRC to coordinate emergency relief, build regional resilience, and negotiate aid access in crisis zones

State of Palestine

The Palestine issue remains one of the main causes of conflict in the Middle East. Many countries and international organizations believe that peace in the region cannot happen without



a fair solution for Palestine. The conflict has continued to affect regional peace and stability for many years.

Israel's settlement activities in occupied Palestinian territories, including East Jerusalem, are considered illegal under international law. Palestinians continue to face displacement, restrictions, and violence in the occupied territories. The two-state solution is still widely supported as the main path toward peace.

The humanitarian situation in Gaza continues to worsen, with civilians suffering the most. There have been repeated calls for the protection of civilians and for humanitarian aid to reach affected areas without restrictions.

Regional actors and Palestinian armed groups continue to influence the conflict and regional security. At the same time, more than 140 UN member states have recognized the State of Palestine, and the international community continues to support diplomatic dialogue and negotiations for peace.

NATO

NATO has been concerned about the growing tensions between Iran and Israel because the conflict could affect peace and stability in the Middle East. Many NATO countries fear that a larger war could spread across the region and involve more countries.

Several NATO members, especially the United States, United Kingdom, France, and Germany, have supported diplomatic talks and called for restraint from both Iran and Israel. NATO countries have also focused on protecting civilians and preventing further military escalation.

The alliance is also worried about threats to important maritime trade routes such as the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea. Any disruption in these areas could affect global oil supplies, international trade, and global economic stability.

Actions Taken by the International Community

2015

- **Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA):** The nation of Iran, the P5+1 nations and the European Union signed a document known as the JCPOA in an attempt to limit the nuclear program of Iran. They offered sanction relief in exchange. The agreement came to be known as the biggest and most significant diplomatic breakthrough in the conflict-filled region of the Middle East. The agreement was signed in an attempt to de-escalate nuclear tensions between Iran, Israel, and other European nations.



- **United States Withdrawal from the JCPOA:** The United States left the JCPOA nuclear agreement and reimposed sanctions on Iran, specifically on the city of Tehran, the capital of Iran. This controversial decision led to increased instability in the region and space for reduced talks regarding the nuclear activities executed by the Islamic Republic of Iran.

2020

- **United Nations Calls for Regional De-escalation:** After the assassination of General Qasem Soleimani (Iran) on the 3rd of January 2020, the United Nations, European Union, and several other regional countries called for peace talks to avoid another and a larger conflict involving the nations- Iran, Israel, and the United States of America.

- **Abraham Accords:** Under U.S. monitoring, Israel established diplomatic relations with the UAE and Bahrain. This action changed the past regional alliances and further led to increased tensions between Iran and several Gulf States, such as Saudi Arabia and Bahrain.

2021

- **Vienna Nuclear Negotiations:** International talks held in Vienna, Switzerland, to hopefully revive the JCPOA nuclear agreement after the United States had withdrawn from it. Many countries, such as Russia and China, supported the talks to possibly reduce tensions and put limits on Iran's nuclear program.

2023

- **United Nations General Assembly Resolution on Gaza:** After the Hamas attacks on Israel and many military operations in Gaza by the State of Israel, the United Nations General Assembly called for ceasefires, taking into consideration the protection of the people, and also humanitarian aid for injured civilians.
- **Red Sea Maritime Security Operations:** Many international naval forces, including those for the United States, made a collaborative effort to keep checks on the Red Sea. This was done to ensure that no commercial ship is attacked by hostile Iranian groups when passing.



Timeline of the Iran-Israel conflict

NOTE: The timeline of events which have been stated after March 2, 2026 (The Crisis Timeline) will be the binding series of events which the committee will follow. Use of any other series of past events or facts derived from them will be completely invalid.

1948

The creation of the State of Israel from Palestinian territories ignites the Arab-Israeli conflict, embedding hostility across the Middle East and laying the foundation for future proxy rivalries. This moment marks the beginning of a prolonged regional dispute over sovereignty, identity, and territorial legitimacy.

1979

The Iranian Revolution transforms Iran into an Islamic Republic; Israel has officially been declared an existential enemy. This ideological shift redefines regional alignments and introduces a sustained political and strategic rivalry.

1982

A major armed non-state actor emerges in Lebanon, becoming a significant force in regional dynamics and border tensions with Israel. Its presence introduces a persistent low-intensity conflict environment along Israel's northern frontier.

1990–1991

The Gulf War reshapes Middle Eastern alliances, increasing U.S. military presence in the region and intensifying perceptions of strategic encirclement. It also solidifies external military involvement as a constant factor in regional security calculations.

2003

The U.S. invasion of Iraq collapses a regional buffer, allowing new power structures and influence networks to emerge. This shift contributes to a gradual rebalancing of regional influence and increased instability.

2006



The Israel–Hezbollah War demonstrates the growing intensity of asymmetric warfare in the region.

It highlights the effectiveness of non-conventional strategies in challenging state military power.

2011

The Syrian Civil War erupts; multiple regional actors become involved, transforming Syria into a strategic battleground.

This results in military proximity between long-standing adversaries, increasing the risk of direct confrontation.

2015

The Iran Nuclear Deal (JCPOA) temporarily eases tensions, but underlying mistrust continues to shape geopolitical decisions.

The agreement introduces verification mechanisms while leaving broader regional rivalries unresolved.

2018

The U.S. withdraws from the JCPOA; sanctions return, and Iran begins scaling up uranium enrichment.

This development reintroduces uncertainty into nuclear diplomacy and raises concerns over proliferation risks.

2020

The assassination of Qasem Soleimani intensifies direct confrontation risks between Iran and the United States.

It signals a shift toward more overt forms of engagement and retaliation in the region.

2023–2025

Repeated Israel– Hamas escalations and regional proxy clashes push the Middle East into a near-constant state of instability.

The frequency of cross-border incidents significantly increases the likelihood of multi-front escalation.



THE CRISIS TIMELINE

Cut-off Date & Time: 2 March 2026 (10:30 AM)

MARCH 2026

2 March 2026 [10:20 AM (IRST)]: THE HORMUZ SHUTDOWN

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps Navy (IRGCN) officially declares the Strait of Hormuz closed to all international maritime traffic, citing what Tehran calls *"acts of Zionist aggression enabled by Western complicity."* Within hours, IRGC vessels began deploying a combination of contact mines and pressure-sensitive smart mines across the strait's navigational channels. Iranian coastal defense batteries are placed on maximum alert. At this point insurance companies like the Lloyd's of London immediately suspend insurance for all vessels attempting transit. Global oil markets go into freefall and the price of crude oil spikes to **\$147 per barrel** within 36 hours, the highest since the 2008 crisis.

3 March 2026 — THE MARKET SHOCKWAVE

Asian markets open to chaos. The Sensex sheds nearly 6% and European futures signal a brutal opening. The IMF formally issues an emergency statement warning of *"systemic risk to the global economy"* if the strait remains closed beyond 72 hours. Saudi Arabia, despite its fraught relationship with Iran, privately urges Washington to act fast, fearing its own Aramco export pipelines could be targeted next.

4–5 March 2026 — THE U.S. RESPONSE BEGINS

The United States Indo-Pacific Command activates **Operation Iron Tide**. The **USS Carl Vinson Carrier Strike Group**, already positioned in the Arabian Sea following tensions in February, is redirected toward the Gulf of Oman. Two additional Arleigh Burke-class destroyers; the *USS Fitzgerald* and *USS Gravelly* are ordered to take forward positions at the mouth of the strait. The Pentagon issues a terse statement: *"The United States considers the freedom of navigation in international waterways a matter of national security and will take all necessary measures to restore it."* Iran responds by scrambling F-14 Tomcats and drone squadrons along its southern coastline while also commanding its naval fleet to remain on standby.

7 March 2026 — MINE CASUALTIES: FIRST BLOOD



The French-owned supertanker **MV Louis VI**, attempting to exit the strait before the order of closure, strikes an IRGC pressure mine 11 nautical miles southwest of Bandar Abbas. The explosion tears open two cargo holds. 4 crew members are killed, 17 injured. The tanker, carrying 2.1 million barrels of Saudi crude, begins listing. Iran refuses to allow international rescue vessels access to the area, calling the incident *"a consequence of defying the sovereign security zone of the Islamic Republic."* The UK and France immediately summon Iranian ambassadors.

9 March 2026 — NATO RESPONSE

An emergency session of the NATO Council is convened in Brussels. While full military intervention is off the table for now, NATO activates its **Article 4 consultation mechanism** at the request of Turkey and France, both severely impacted by shipping disruptions. The alliance announces it will deploy an **AWACS surveillance aircraft** to the region and begin coordinating naval escorts for allied vessels. Turkey in a controversial move, signals it will not fully align with NATO's posture, citing its ongoing energy agreements with Iran.

THE REST OF MARCH

The following weeks of March see the conflict shift from a regional military standoff into something far more dangerous — a multi-domain confrontation with no clear ceiling. U.S. intelligence **claims** a joint operation between **IRGC Cyber Command** and **Chinese state-sponsored hacking group** APT 31 had been silently burrowing into the core infrastructure of American Big tech companies like **Meta, Google, Apple, Microsoft and Amazon** which had been into existence right since the day Iran's supreme leader had been assassinated. The effects were immediate and cascading. China and Iran have both denied any claims of involvement.

A 14-hour global outage cripples Meta's platforms, severing communications for billions across the Middle East, Africa and Southeast Asia. Apple's satellite communication firmware is found compromised, and Google confirms mass exfiltration of geolocation and user data with a disturbing focus on Gulf states, Israeli territory, and U.S. overseas bases. Days later, a far deeper layer of disruptions is discovered with dual-use orbiting satellites which were tampered with, causing signal degradation.

APRIL 2026

Early April (1st – 16th April)

The month opens with a full-scale missile exchange between Iran and the United States. The IRGC launches ballistic and cruise missile strikes on U.S. bases across the Middle East region — Al Udeid, Camp Arifjan and the Naval Support Activity in Bahrain all sustain significant damage with dozens of American casualties. United States Central Command (CENTCOM)



retaliates with Tomahawk strikes on IRGC naval and missile installations. The exchange settles into a grinding, near-daily rhythm of strike and counterstrike. Iran simultaneously widens its target list, launching a devastating combined missile and drone assault on the UAE and Qatar striking the **Jumeirah corridor** in Dubai, damaging significant parts of **Burj Al Arab** and **Burj Khalifa**, and hitting the **West Bay district** in Doha. The attacks prove a strategic miscalculation: the UAE formally expels all U.S. military forces from its territory and files a \$75 billion reparations claim against Iran through the ICJ, which Tehran flatly rejects. American strikes on Iran, meanwhile, draw fierce international condemnation after hitting power infrastructure and civilian-adjacent areas including a strike near an elementary school in Mashhad that kills dozens. The cyber and technological war continues to intensify — the London Stock Exchange suffers its first successful cyberattack in history, SWIFT issues security alerts, and U.S. Cyber Command, working with Israeli Unit 8200, disables monitoring systems at Fordow and Natanz(Iran).

17 April — *The Selective Opening*

Iran announces a partial, selective reopening of the Strait of Hormuz permitting passage exclusively to vessels from China, India, Oman, Indonesia, South Africa and Brazil, while maintaining the closure for all Western and American shipping. The announcement is delivered flanked by the Chinese and Indian ambassadors to Tehran, making its diplomatic intent unmistakable. Beijing welcomes it but officials at Washington became furious.

- The Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi formally stated:

"The Strait of Hormuz is open today but let me be absolutely clear about who it is open for: Chinese and Indian vessels, along with those of select nations that have honoured Iranian sovereignty, may pass freely and safely. For the United States and its Western allies, the strait remains what it has been since March 2nd — closed, and it will stay that way until Washington learns the difference between negotiation and intimidation."

Late April (18th – 31st April)

Enraged by the selective reopening, the U.S. launched a systematic campaign targeting Iranian economic energy infrastructure striking the Kharg Island oil terminal, South Pars gas processing facilities and national communications infrastructure. Iran retaliates asymmetrically, hitting American big tech offices across the Middle East: a bombing at Google's Dubai hub, a device found at Microsoft's Riyadh offices, and a sophisticated combined drone-and-cyber assault on Amazon's Bahrain data centre that takes it offline for over 60 hours. Israel, largely quiet since March, re-enters the picture as intelligence confirms accelerated enrichment activity at Fordow under cover of the wider conflict, and Hezbollah resumes large-scale rocket fire into northern Israel. The Israeli Air Force strikes Hezbollah positions in Lebanon and the defence forces begin mobilising reserve divisions along the northern border, a signal directed as much at Tehran as at Beirut. The month closes with a UN-supervised three-day diplomatic session between senior American and Iranian diplomats in Geneva on 29, 30 and 31 April that collapses spectacularly: Iranian demands are described by American delegates as impossibly maximalist, decorum breaks



down entirely on the second day, and the Iranian delegation walks out on the 31st with no joint statement, no roadmap, and no date for future talks.

MAY 2026

Early May (1st – 10th May)

The missile exchanges from April carry seamlessly into May with no sign of abatement — U.S. strikes continue hammering Iranian energy infrastructure while Iranian missile strikes now retaliate targeting Western big-tech infrastructure, including data centers, in the middle east. In the first week, the **New York Stock Exchange, NASDAQ, and the London Stock Exchange** suffer simultaneous trading disruptions traced by a CIA report to IRGC-affiliated hackers operating with substantial Chinese logistical support.. The incident draws sharp statements from the G7 but little immediate action, quickly overtaken by the far larger events to follow.

Mid May (11th – 22nd May)

The conflict enters a new and alarming dimension when a **coordinated intelligence assessment**, jointly produced by the CIA, MI6, BND and the French DGSE is presented to Western governments confirming that Iran has been systematically procuring **black market uranium** through clandestine networks spanning **Brazil, Namibia, Kazakhstan and several Central American states**. The quantities involved, combined with the accelerated enrichment activity already detected at Fordow, suggest a program far more advanced than publicly acknowledged. The United States responds with overwhelming force on the diplomatic and economic front by shifting its military power to **DEFCON 4** and announcing sweeping secondary sanctions on all identified exporting nations and their state energy entities, and deploying U.S. Navy assets into the **maritime approaches of Brazil and Namibia** to monitor shipping lanes and interdict any Iranian-linked cargo vessels.

The operation, however, produces a catastrophe that instantly eclipses the policy it was meant to enforce. On **May 16th**, a U.S. naval vessel operating in the South Atlantic intercepted what its commanders believed to be an Iranian-chartered cargo ship approximately 40 nautical miles off **Rio de Janeiro**. The vessel is, in fact, the **Brazilian civilian cruise liner MV Esperança do Mar**, carrying 847 passengers and crew on a coastal voyage. In a catastrophic intelligence failure, the ship is struck by a naval missile and sinks within 22 minutes. There are no survivors. The world reacts with undiluted horror. Brazil immediately suspends all diplomatic relations with the United States, recalls its ambassador, and files charges of **unlawful killing and state aggression** at the International Court of Justice. Anti-American protests erupt in São Paulo, Buenos Aires, Caracas and Mexico City. Even traditional U.S. allies privately express revulsion. Washington offers condolences and promises a full investigation — words that satisfy almost no one.



The wider region, meanwhile, grows more fractured by the day. **Syrian forces** report renewed skirmishes along the **Golan Heights**, with small but persistent provocations that Israeli border units respond to with air interdiction strikes. **Hamas**, after months of relative dormancy, begins a gradual resumption of rocket fire from Gaza into southern Israel the funding and resupply lines, according to Israeli and Western intelligence assessments, bearing unmistakable hallmarks of **Russian** financial facilitation, likely channelled through intermediary networks in Damascus and Beirut. **Iraq's government**, already struggling to maintain neutrality, reports that IRGC-aligned militia groups have seized control of two border crossings with Iran, effectively making them Iranian logistical corridors. In **Lebanon**, Hezbollah increased its operational tempo, and the government in Beirut powerless to stop it approached the New York Headquarters of the UN for help. **Egypt**, watching the Red Sea shipping lanes destabilise alongside the Hormuz closure, places its military on elevated alert and closes the Suez Canal to vessels it deems carrying conflict-linked cargo; a decision that sends another shockwave through global shipping markets.

25 May 2026 — *The Strait Goes Dark*

Late in May, Iranian authorities announced that they had uncovered compelling evidence that **multiple vessels** that transited the Strait of Hormuz under Chinese and Indian flags since the selective reopening on April 17th were in fact **American ships operating under false registration and disguised markings**; their true cargo and mission unknown. Iran presents shipping manifests, satellite imagery and hull identification discrepancies to the UN and demands an immediate international inquiry. Washington neither confirms nor denies. The accusation detonates what little remained of the diplomatic negotiations.

At **9:00 PM Iran Standard Time** on **25 May 2026**, the Islamic Republic of Iran announces the total, unconditional closure of the Strait of Hormuz to every nation on earth without exception. Within the hour, IRGC naval units moved to seal both entry and exit points. At the time of closure, **120 vessels of various nationalities** — tankers, cargo ships, LNG carriers are caught inside the strait with nowhere to go. They drop anchor and wait.

Within 24 hours of the blockade, every navigation system within the strait goes dark simultaneously. GPS signals vanish. AIS transponders return no data. Radar systems aboard vessels report interference so total it renders them useless. Satellite uplinks from ships in the strait whether commercial, civilian or military go silent. All 120 vessels lost complete communication with their national authorities, their companies, and their crews' families. Their locations remain unknown to national agencies across the world.

The Director of World's Largest Shipping company, MSC releases the statement at midnight for their 5 massive ships stuck in the Strait of Hormuz —

“They are lost in the sea”



No government claims responsibility. No known technology is formally identified as the cause. Analysts gesture toward EM, directed-energy jamming systems, or a combination of cyber and signal warfare of a sophistication the world has not previously witnessed, but no one knows. No international body steps forward with answers. For the first time since the crisis erupted, nobody had any answers.

JUNE 2026

Early June (1st – 14th June)

The bombardments that defined May carry into June without pause. U.S. strikes continue targeting Iranian energy and government infrastructure while Iranian cyber and missile units maintain their campaign against Western technological and military assets across the region. The situation inside the Strait of Hormuz remains unresolved with the 120 trapped vessels unable to pass. .

Mid June (15th – 20th June)

On a dawn morning in mid-June, seismic monitoring stations across South Asia, the Gulf and Central Asia simultaneously register an anomalous ground vibration signature originating from a remote desert corridor near the **Iranian-Pakistani border**. Within minutes, satellite imagery confirms what the readings suggested — Iran has just conducted a successful test launch of an **Intercontinental Ballistic Missile (ICBM)** of previously undocumented range and payload capacity, the projectile arcing deep into the upper atmosphere before splashing down in a designated zone in the Gulf of Oman.

No such missile was known to exist in Iran's arsenal. Its range envelope, as hastily calculated by defence analysts in Washington, Moscow, Beijing and New Delhi simultaneously, places **Continental Europe, Central Asia** and the **Eastern seaboard of the United States** within theoretical strike distance. Its guidance precision, based on trajectory data, suggests a level of inertial and possibly satellite-assisted navigation technology that Iran was not by any publicly available intelligence assessment believed to possess. The propulsion signature does not match any known Iranian domestic program. And that, to every intelligence agency now poring over the telemetry data in frantic all-night sessions, is the most disturbing finding of all.

Questions flood classified briefings and open press conferences alike — ***How did Iran acquire this? Is this a scientific marvel they had been working on or is there some foreign actor involved?***

Satellite imagery of the launch facility shows construction activity dating back at least **18 months** — meaning this was planned, funded and built during a period when the world's attention was elsewhere. Russia offers no comment. China calls it "*an internal matter of Iranian sovereign defence.*" North Korea does not respond to any inquiry. The delegates of the world are



left to connect the dots themselves and the picture they draw will determine everything that follows.

Late June (21st – 28th June)

The ICBM test detonates a political crisis inside the United States unlike anything seen since the Cuban Missile Crisis. **DEFCON 3** is declared; "*Round House*," signifying the Air Force ready to mobilise in fifteen minutes — the first time the United States has reached this alert level in decades. The declaration itself becomes a domestic flashpoint. American public opinion, already strained by months of casualties, economic pain and the Brazilian cruise ship disaster, fractures visibly and loudly. One fragment of people demands a total, overwhelming military response to "*remove the Iranian regime from the map once and for all*." Another, equally vocal comprising anti-war movements, progressive legislators, and an exhausted general public takes to the streets of New York, Chicago, Los Angeles and Washington demanding an immediate ceasefire and the **resignation of the Secretary of War**.

In the Gulf region, Iran dramatically escalates its campaign against American corporate presence in the Gulf. The **Amazon MENA headquarters in Riyadh** is struck by a precision drone assault that destroys three floors and kills 19 people. **Meta's regional hub in Dubai** is car-bombed for the second time, this time with far greater devastation, the building is rendered structurally unsound and evacuated permanently. Supply chains across Saudi Arabia buckle as IRGC-aligned cyber units **allegedly** target **Saudi Aramco's operational logistics software**, causing cascading disruptions to refinery scheduling, export documentation and pipeline flow management. The Saudi government, which has maintained an uneasy semi-neutrality, begins quiet back-channel conversations with both Washington and Tehran stating nothing publicly.

29 June 2026 — *The Strike on Bandar Abbas*

At approximately **6:40 AM local time**, a drone strike hits a convoy moving through the port district of **Bandar Abbas**. Within hours, the identity of the target is beyond dispute — **Brigadier General Ahmad Vahidi**, Commander-in-Chief of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, is killed instantly along with four senior IRGC officers. Israel, having said nothing, requested nothing, and coordinated with no one, quietly confirms through a single PMO statement that the **Israeli Air Force** conducted the operation unilaterally, describing it as "*an act of sovereign defence against the architect of existential threats to the State of Israel*." The U.S. is visibly caught off guard, offering neither endorsement nor condemnation in the first 24 hours.

JULY 2026

Early July (1st – 14th July)



The killing of Vahidi by Israeli hands sends shockwaves through the region, pushing Iranian rhetoric toward Israel to its most incendiary pitch yet. It is in this charged atmosphere, however, that the most unexpected diplomatic development of the crisis takes shape. **India**, leveraging its unique position as a nation with open channels to Tehran, genuine strategic independence from Washington, and credibility with both sides, steps forward as mediator. A week of shuttle diplomacy by Indian NSA Ajit Doval produces the **Delhi Preliminary Understanding (July 2026)**, Iran halts attacks on foreign corporate infrastructure and Middle Eastern Civilian Areas, the U.S. scales back strikes on Iranian civilian zones and Energy Infrastructure. Iran on the other hand maintains closure of the Strait of Hormuz but allows the 120 stuck ships to finally pass by. Neither side calls it a ceasefire. Both sides know it is the closest thing to one they have managed in four months.

Mid July (15th – 21st July)

The visible reduction in hostilities is real but paper-thin. No missiles fly, no corporate targets are struck, and for the first time since February a week passes without a major headline death toll. But in the classified spaces the picture is entirely different. Western intelligence agency media leaks **report** that both Iran and the United States are engaged in detailed contingency planning for large-scale escalation, war-gaming scenarios that dwarf anything seen so far. Every military asset remains in its forward position. The Delhi Understanding has paused the war. It has not ended. Everyone who matters knows this.

22–25 July 2026 — The Hijack

On **22nd July**, El Al Flight 447 en route from Tel Aviv to Bangkok was hijacked over the Red Sea and diverted to **Tripoli, Libya**. Six hijackers hold 298 passengers and crew for 31 hours while negotiations collapse. On **25th July**, Israeli Sayeret Matkal operatives inserted covertly into Libya executed a high-risk rescue operation, all passengers extracted alive, all six hijackers killed. Israel confirms the operation. Libya protests the sovereignty violation. Iran denies involvement but the timing and the target leave the corridors of the UN buzzing with inference.

THE FINAL WEEK (21 JULY onwards)

The final days before the UNSC conference are defined by a weariness that has settled over the entire international system. The United States, battered by months of domestic political fracture, economic pain, the Brazilian cruise ship disaster and a DEFCON 3 that has sat unresolved for weeks, steps to the global stage and issues a measured but unambiguous statement: **America is standing down its offensive operations against Iran** — not permanently, not unconditionally, but for now.



27th July 2026 — *The Final Day*

14:00 hrs Gulf Standard Time — First Detection

Radar systems across the Gulf region along with independently operating India's DRDO surveillance networks detect the launch of a ballistic missile from **Al Udeid Air Base, Qatar**. The missile tracks northeast. Iranian air defence algorithms compute its projected impact point within minutes.

Projected target: The Reshadat oil field complex, southern Iran.

The launch origin is not in dispute. Indian tracking confirms it. Iranian radar confirms it. The missile is American. It is airborne.

T + 2 Minutes — Iran Retaliates

The **Khorramabad Underground Missile Base** executes a pre-authorised retaliatory launch — a ballistic missile targeted at the **American consulate in Sharjah, UAE**. The launch is automatic, the product of algorithmic retaliation protocols embedded into Iran's defence architecture after the Delhi Understanding was signed.

This confirms that Iran had never stopped preparing for the moment the Delhi Understanding would break.

T + 4 Minutes — First Interception

The Iranian missile crosses into UAE airspace and approaches Dubai. It is intercepted cleanly by a **U.S. Patriot PAC-3 battery** operating from a naval vessel in the Gulf.

There are no casualties.

T + 6 Minutes — The Trajectory Shift

At almost the exact same moment, the American missile **silently and without explanation changes its trajectory**, veering away from the Reshadat oil field, curving northward by approximately 100 kilometres, before being intercepted by Iranian air defence systems in the vicinity of an **IRGC military installation**.

Washington later claims this was the intended target from the outset. Iranian authorities have claimed this to be a fabrication.

Nobody till now has been able to independently verify either claim.



The Aftermath

Iran condemns the United States claiming that it launched the first strike which is a direct violation of the Delhi Understanding that both nations signed and promised to honour.

According to the **USA**, The Delhi Understanding covered civilian energy infrastructure and corporate targets only. Military infrastructure was **never included in the text**. Furthermore, Iran is guilty of the graver breach for launching a missile toward a consulate in Sharjah, a civilian diplomatic zone in a neutral country.

Evening of 27th July — DEFCON 2

That evening, U.S. Secretary of State **Marco Rubio** issues a formal public statement — the starkest language from Washington since the crisis began:

"Any further offensive action by the Islamic Republic of Iran against American personnel, assets, allies or interests will be considered an act of war and will be met with a response of overwhelming and decisive force. The United States will not be responsible for the consequences of Iranian miscalculation."

Important Topics for Further Research and Discussion

I. Political Stance & Decision-Making

Topics:

- Domestic political factors influencing Iranian foreign policy
- Israeli security doctrine and military decision-making
- Role of hardliners and moderates in negotiations
- Political consequences of ceasefires and concessions
- Public opinion and wartime policymaking

Questions of Concern:

- How do domestic political pressures affect the willingness of states to negotiate?
- To what extent do ideological narratives shape foreign policy decisions?
- Can political leadership survive major diplomatic compromises?
- How do internal political divisions impact peace efforts?



II. UNSC & International Diplomacy

Topics:

- Previous UNSC resolutions on Iran and regional security
- Role of veto powers in preventing UNSC action
- Feasibility of UN-monitored ceasefires
- Sanctions as tools of diplomacy
- Peacekeeping and observer missions in conflict

Questions of Concern:

- How can the UNSC effectively prevent further escalation?
- Should the UNSC prioritize sanctions or diplomacy?
- How can ceasefire agreements be monitored and enforced?
- What limitations do veto powers create during international crises?

III. Nuclear De-escalation & Arms Control

Topics:

- Revival or restructuring of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action

Questions of Concern:

- Is reviving the JCPOA necessary for regional stability?
- How does nuclear uncertainty contribute to insecurity?
- Can regional de-escalation succeed without nuclear negotiations?
- How can trust in nuclear inspections be restored?

IV. Proxy Warfare & Non-State Actors

Topics:

- Role of proxy militias in regional escalation
- Influence of Hezbollah and regional armed groups
- Proxy warfare and plausible deniability
- Accountability of non-state actors
- Integration of militias into peace processes

Questions of Concern:

- How can proxy warfare be contained?
- To what extent are states responsible for the actions of proxy groups?
- Can peace agreements succeed without involving non-state actors?
- How do proxy attacks increase risks of regional war?



V. Military De-escalation & Security

Topics:

- Crisis communication mechanisms between adversaries
- Missile defense systems and deterrence stability
- Drone warfare in modern conflict
- Preventing accidental military escalation
- Military transparency and confidence-building
- Demilitarized zones and buffer arrangements

Questions of Concern:

- How can accidental escalation be prevented?
- Do deterrence strategies increase or reduce instability?
- Can military transparency improve regional trust?
- What mechanisms can reduce retaliation cycles?

VI. Maritime & Energy Security

Topics:

- Strategic importance of the Strait of Hormuz
- Maritime security operations
- Protection of global shipping routes
- Oil diplomacy and energy security
- Naval escalation in the Persian Gulf
- Economic consequences of trade disruption

Questions of Concern:

- How can freedom of navigation be protected during conflict?
- What impact would maritime disruption have on global energy markets?
- Should international naval coalitions intervene in regional waterways
- How can economic instability caused by conflict be minimized?

VII. Cyber Warfare & Emerging Technologies

Topics:

- Cyberattacks on critical infrastructure
- AI-enabled warfare and escalation risks
- Information warfare and propaganda
- Digital misinformation during armed conflict



- Protection of civilian cyber infrastructure
- International regulation of cyberwarfare

Questions of Concern:

- How can cyberwarfare escalation be controlled?
- Should international law regulate cyber operations during conflict?
- What role does misinformation play in escalating tensions?
- How can civilian infrastructure be protected from cyberattacks?

VIII. Humanitarian Concerns & Civilian Protection

Topics:

- Civilian protection during interstate conflict
- Humanitarian corridors and aid delivery
- Refugee displacement and regional instability
- Protection of hospitals and energy infrastructure
- Humanitarian law during armed conflict
- Post-conflict reconstruction and stabilization

Questions of Concern:

- How can civilian casualties be minimized during hostilities?
- What mechanisms ensure humanitarian access in conflict zones?
- How should the international community respond to humanitarian crises?
- Who should bear responsibility for post-conflict reconstruction?

IX. Long-Term Conflict Resolution

Topics:

- Confidence-building measures between rival states
- Lessons from previous Middle East peace agreements
- Track I and Track II diplomacy
- Long-term regional security frameworks
- Sustainable peacebuilding mechanisms
- Addressing ideological and sectarian tensions

Questions of Concern:

- What conditions are necessary for sustainable peace?
- Can deterrence coexist with diplomacy?
- Why have previous peace efforts failed?
- How can long-term trust be rebuilt between adversaries?



Questions a Resolution Must Answer

Delegates, these are some of the questions about the underlying crisis at hand that the Executive Board expects to be discussed in the committee. The draft resolution must address the questions in some capacity:

I. Legality, Sovereignty, and Use of Force

1. Under what provisions of international law (e.g., UNCLOS, UN Charter Articles 2(4) and 51) can the closure of a strategic chokepoint like the Strait of Hormuz be justified or condemned?
2. Does the declaration of Hormuz as a “restricted military zone” constitute an act of war or a defensive sovereign measure?
3. What legal thresholds must be met for pre-emptive or retaliatory strikes in this conflict?
4. How can the international community ensure accountability for violations of sovereignty, including airspace intrusions and targeted strikes?

II. Maritime Security and Global Trade Stability

1. How can freedom of navigation be restored and guaranteed in the Strait of Hormuz amid active conflict?
2. Should an international naval coalition or UN-mandated force be deployed to secure critical sea lanes?
3. What mechanisms can be implemented to prevent the weaponization of global energy supply chains?
4. How should states respond to the targeting or seizure of commercial vessels during the crisis?

III. Leadership Crisis and State Stability (Iran Focus)

1. How does the sudden death of Iran’s Supreme Leader impact command-and-control over military and proxy forces?
2. What risks does a fragmented leadership structure pose to nuclear command authority and escalation control?
3. Should external actors engage with interim or factional leadership within Iran, and under what conditions?
4. How can internal instability be prevented from spilling into regional or global conflict?



IV. Nuclear Risk and Strategic Deterrence

1. What measures can prevent nuclear escalation amid rising hostilities and breakdown of trust?
2. How should the international community respond to threats of nuclear transfer or proliferation during the crisis?
3. Are existing treaties (e.g., NPT frameworks) sufficient to address the current situation, or do emergency protocols need to be created?
4. What role should nuclear powers play in de-escalation without exacerbating bloc confrontation?

V. Cyber Warfare and Hybrid Conflict

1. How should cyberattacks on financial systems, defence networks, and critical infrastructure be classified under international law?
2. What norms or red lines must be established for cyber operations during active geopolitical crises?
3. How can attribution challenges in cyber warfare be addressed to ensure accountability?
4. Should cyber retaliation be treated as equivalent to a kinetic military response?

VI. Proxy Warfare and Non-State Actors

1. To what extent are states accountable for the actions of proxy militias and allied non-state actors?
2. How can the funding, arming, and coordination of proxy groups be effectively monitored and restricted?
3. What mechanisms can prevent regional actors from escalating the conflict indirectly?
4. Should there be sanctions or enforcement actions specifically targeting proxy warfare networks?

VII. Humanitarian Impact and Civilian Protection

1. How can civilian populations in conflict zones and surrounding regions be protected from escalation?
2. What immediate humanitarian corridors or ceasefire mechanisms can be implemented?
3. How should displaced populations and refugee flows resulting from the crisis be managed?
4. What accountability frameworks should exist for civilian casualties and infrastructure damage?

VIII. Economic Warfare and Global Financial Stability



1. How should the international community respond to currency destabilization and energy price shocks triggered by the crisis?
2. What safeguards can be implemented to prevent a global economic downturn linked to the conflict?
3. Should economic sanctions be intensified, relaxed, or restructured to encourage de-escalation?
4. How can developing economies be protected from the spread effects of this geopolitical crisis?

Position Paper Policy

A position paper is a brief overview of a country's stance on the topics being discussed by a particular committee. Though there is no specific format that the position paper must follow, it should include a description of the position your country holds on the issues on the agenda, relevant actions that your country has taken, and potential solutions that your country would support.

Purpose:

Keep in mind the recent decisions taken by your own country and major events that have taken place after the war and your foreign policy regarding the same. The Position papers should include the following details:

- **Delegate's preliminary understanding** of the topic and what it entails;
- **Allocation of the delegate and your stance** on this agenda;
- **Negotiable and Non-Negotiable compromises** in context to your portfolio (Highly Encouraged);
- **Information regarding your portfolio** that you think that the Executive Board members should know;
- **Expectations as to how this committee should progress** and what are your expectations from the debate;
- Solutions and Proposed Plan of Action by the country can be mentioned but is **NOT** required.

Each position paper should not exceed two pages (ignoring the Bibliography and any intext citations) and should all be combined into a single PDF format per delegate (other formats will not be accepted.)

Formatting:

To ensure uniformity and professionalism, all position papers must follow the formatting guidelines below:

Header Information

At the top of the first page, clearly include the following details:



- **Name of the delegate**
- **Country being represented**
- **Committee name**
- **Agenda being discussed**

Font and Spacing

- Use a standard academic font, preferably **Times New Roman**
- Font size should be **12-point**
- Maintain **1-inch (2.54 cm) margins** on all sides
- Use **1.5 or 1.15 spacing** for readability
- **Justify your text** for a clean appearance

Tone and Language

- **Third person perspective** (representing a state)
- **Formal and diplomatic tone**
- **No colloquialisms** or emotional language

Citations and Bibliography

- **Properly cite** all sources to avoid plagiarism
- **APA or MLA format** for the bibliography

File Submission Format

- **PDF format** only
- **Country_Committee_WELMUN26.pdf** naming convention

Failure to comply with these formatting requirements may result in penalties, reduced eligibility for awards, or the rejection of your position paper. Submitting a well-researched and properly formatted paper demonstrates preparedness and respect for the procedural integrity of the committee.

Due Dates and Submission Procedure:

Position papers for this committee must be submitted by midnight of July 20, 2026. Each position paper will be manually reviewed by the Executive Board. All position papers have to be mailed at the committee email-id. The email address for this committee is

chair.unsc@welhamboys.org

Other Important Information:

The position paper will be subjected to common AI-based and Plagiarism detection tools. Any specific citation of International Law, Treaty, Agreement or event must be supplemented with reports from a News Agency, Organization or an International Body and will be deemed NOT CREDIBLE or PLAGIARISED in case the aforementioned is not provided.



The position paper is NOT a platform to introduce new events furthering your foreign policy. The futuristic nature of this committee is not one to be exploited. Position Paper CANNOT serve as a document to introduce a plan of action into your own nation, and can merely propose potential actions the country can take. Any foreign policy clarifications by the country that is not mentioned in the Background Guide must be explicitly addressed during the committee proceedings in the interest of the other delegates..

Documentation Guidelines

The following aims to introduce the types of documentation which will be accepted during the course of the committee. Delegates are requested to go through the document thoroughly to acquaint themselves with the format and procedure for the same. Moreover, there is NO restriction on the length of a document. However, the documentations can only influence the flow of the committee after the executive board has approved of it. The formats of all documentation and the list of allowed operative and preambulatory clauses have been attached in the appendix.

Presidential Statement

- Official communication issued by the leader of the country;
- Used to indicate a **change in foreign policy** in lieu of a crisis;
- Must be formatted in a **first-person narrative**;
- Circulated and subject to **Points of Information** by the Press Corps.

Once a presidential statement has been accepted by the Executive Board, it will be read out by the executive board. Following this, the Executive Board will entertain verbal points of information to the presidential statement by members of the International Press Corps. A presidential statement is not voted upon as it is not within the mandate of the committee to adopt or implement it. Once it has been submitted, it is assumed that the issuing country is already taking the actions mentioned in it within its own capacity.

Joint Press Release

- Statement made collectively by authorities of **two or more countries**;
- Accepted only if it **significantly impacts debate**.

Once a joint press release has been accepted by the Executive Board, it will be read out by the delegates of the issuing countries. Following this, the Executive Board will entertain verbal points of information to the press release by members of the International Press Corps. A joint press release is not voted upon as it is not within the mandate of the committee to adopt or implement it. Once it has been submitted, it is assumed that the contracting countries are already taking the actions mentioned in it within their own capacity.



Committee-Wide Press Release

- Issued and supported by **ALL member states**;
- Passed by default with **unanimous agreement**;
- **Non-binding** and cannot substitute a formal resolution.

The executive board will confirm from all the member states if there is any country in opposition to the committee-wide press release. In case of an opposition, the press release will be considered null and void. Committee-wide press releases will be considered as an apt response to a particular crisis update taken by the Security Council. However, any action detailed in the committee-wide press release will be non-binding, and cannot be considered a substitute for a Security Council resolution. A Committee-Wide Press Release is at all times superior to a committee-wide directive due to the unanimous agreement required to issue the press release.

Joint Directive

- Collaborative action taken by two or more countries;
 - **Public-Joint Directive**: Contents read out in committee if accepted;
 - **Private-Joint Directive**: Contents not revealed to the committee.

Public-Joint Directive - If accepted by the Executive Board, the contents of a public-joint directive will be read out in the committee.

Private-Joint Directive - Even if it is accepted by the Executive Board, the contents of a private-joint directive will not be read out in committee. **Committee-Wide Directive**

- Implementable action document to solve or prevent issues;
- **Key Procedural Requirements**:
 - **The number of signatories required**: 1/3rd of the committee's total strength;
 - **For the directive to pass**: Simple majority (50% + 1 vote).

Communique (Covert/ Overt)

Communiques are tools used to contact entities outside of your committee in order to involve them with the crisis in a certain way. They are written as formal correspondence to outside actors as a way of enticing them to take action, even though they aren't under your direct control. You can write communiques as an individual delegate or as a committee. The note of communication can be addressed as 'covert' if the delegate wishes to use a secure line of communication. The communique can be addressed as 'overt' if the delegate wishes to reveal the communication to the committee.



Appendix

Sample Presidential Statement

Presidential Statement by the Russian Federation

To protect the interests and security of the Russian Federation and in accordance with the federal laws of December 30, 2006, No 281-FZ On Special Economic and Coercive Measures and of June 4, 2018, No 127-FZ On Measures (Countermeasures) in Response to Unfriendly Actions of the United States and Other Foreign States, I hereby resolve:

To restrict (including the imposition of a complete ban if necessary) the signing by diplomatic missions and consular agencies, representatives of government bodies and government agencies of foreign states that take unfriendly actions towards the Russian Federation, citizens of the Russian Federation or Russian legal entities, of labor contracts, employment agreements with workers (personnel) and of other civil-law contracts leading to labor relations with individuals on the territory of the Russian Federation.

The Government of the Russian Federation shall:

- a) compile a list of unfriendly foreign states towards which the measures (countermeasures) established by this Executive Order apply;
- b) determine the number of individuals that are on the territory of the Russian Federation and with whom contracts may be signed;

Sample Joint Press Release

Authors: Canada, United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, United States of America, French Republic, Federal Republic of Germany, Kingdom of Spain

We, the governments of Canada, the UK, USA and the EU, are united in our deep concern regarding the Lukashenka regime's continuing attacks on human rights, fundamental freedoms, and international law. Today, we have taken coordinated sanctions action in response to the 23 May forced landing of a commercial Ryanair flight between 2 EU member states and the politically motivated arrest of journalist Raman Pratasevich and his companion Sofia Sapega, as well as to the continuing attack on human rights and fundamental freedoms. We are committed to support the long-suppressed democratic aspirations of the people of Belarus and we stand together to impose costs on the regime for its blatant disregard of international commitments.



We are united in calling for the regime to end its repressive practices against its own people. We are further united in our call for the Lukashenka regime to cooperate fully with international investigations into the events of 23 May; immediately release all political prisoners; implement all the recommendations of the independent expert mission under the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe's (OSCE) Moscow Mechanism; and, enter into a comprehensive and genuine political dialogue between the authorities and representatives of the democratic opposition and civil society, facilitated by the OSCE.

Sample Committee-Wide Press Release

Press Release by the United Nations Security Council

The members of the Security Council welcome the announcement of a ceasefire beginning 21 May and recognize the important role Egypt, other regional countries, the United Nations, the Middle East Quartet and other international partners played in this regard. The Security Council calls for the full adherence to the ceasefire. The members of the Security Council mourn the loss of civilian lives resulting from the violence.

The members of the Security Council stress the immediate need for humanitarian assistance to the Palestinian civilian population, particularly in Gaza, and support the Secretary-General's call for the international community to work with the United Nations on developing an integrated, robust package of support for a swift, sustainable reconstruction and recovery. The members of the Security Council stress the urgency of the restoration of calm in full and reiterate the importance of achieving a comprehensive peace based on the vision of a region where two democratic States, Israel and Palestine, live side by side in peace with secure and recognized borders.

Sample Directive (Personal/ Joint/ Committee-Wide)

Sponsor: Sinan Hasani, Nicolae Ceausescu, Nikolai Ryzhkov

Following measures will be undertaken in the areas of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics:

The borderline security of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics to be heightened due to terrorist movements in the following areas:

- a. In the regions surrounded by the black sea, the Pripyat River and the Neva River security will be provided with Yugoslavian armies consisting of following:
 - i. Soko J-22 Orao (Ground-attack and reconnaissance aircraft)
 - ii. Soko G-4 Super Galeb (Advanced jet trainer and light attack aircraft)
 - iii. Soko G-2 Galej (Jet trainer and light ground-attack aircraft)



b. In the borders of Soviet – Afghanistan establishment of Warsaw pact military forces, including the borders of the Baltic states, including the Red Army.

c. In St. Petersburg, Romania will establish their military forces in the form of ground battalions consisting of Immediate Response squad.

In case of an emergency, the forces in St. Petersburg and the Soviet Police will assist in the evacuation of the nearby areas, including provision of protective radioactive clothing and establishment of a Radioactive Exclusion zone.

In collaboration with the IAEA and the UNHCR (United Nations Office of High Commissioner of refugees), establish refugee shelters for the displaced citizens in the low populated areas like the Serbian region of the Union of soviet socialist republics.

Sample Communiqué (Overt/Covert)

By: Delegate of United States of America

To: Pierre Wigny (Belgium's Head of Department of Ministry of Foreign affairs)

The United States of America requests the Belgium government to launch an all-pervasive attack on the Prime Minister of the Republic of Congo namely Patrice Lumumba and all other harbingers of communism in their nation.

- These actions to be performed with the help of-
 - » Remaining loyal people of the Force publique in Katanga province.
 - » Moise Tshombe and his army of the Confederation of Tribal Associations of Katanga.
 - » The threat of Honest John missiles can be used; However, its actual use is severely prohibited.
- Moise Tshombe and his community to be given the incentive of capturing the Belgium bases of “Kitona” and “Kamina” for further support from the Belgium government.

Any attack or retaliation from a battalion of Union of Soviet Socialist Republics should be immediately informed to the United States of America, and the United Nations Security Council immediately as to trap them into an unescapable hole.

The Belgian government can work behind the scenes of Moise Tshombe and the prospect of a civil war, and work with the government of the United States of America to stop this civil war, in the eyes of the United Nations.

Please keep in mind the other people and reduce collateral damage, so that no citizens are hurt. Only communistic feelings need to be rid of, not the whole population.

For sample draft resolutions, please visit the official website of the United Nations:



List of Preambulatory Clauses

Sample Preambulatory Phrases

Affirming	Expecting	Having studied
Alarmed by	Expressing its appreciation	Keeping in mind
Approving	Expressing its satisfaction	Noting with regret
Aware of	Fulfilling	Noting with deep concern
Bearing in mind	Fully alarmed	Noting with satisfaction
Believing	Fully aware	Noting further
Confident	Fully believing	Noting with approval
Contemplating	Further deploring	Observing
Convinced	Further recalling	Reaffirming
Declaring	Guided by	Realizing
Deeply concerned	Having adopted	Recalling
Deeply conscious	Having considered	Recognizing
Deeply convinced	Having considered further	Referring
Deeply disturbed	Having devoted attention	Seeking
Deeply regretting	Having examined	Taking into account
Desiring	Having heard	Taking into consideration
Emphasizing	Having received	Taking note
		Viewing with appreciation
		Welcoming

List of Operative Clauses

Sample Operative Phrases

Accepts	Encourages	Further recommends
Affirms	Endorses	Further requests
Approves	Expresses its appreciation	Further resolves
Authorizes	Expresses its hope	Has resolved
Calls	Further invites	Notes
Calls upon	Deplores	Proclaims
Condemns	Designates	Reaffirms
Confirms	Draws the attention	Recommends
Congratulates	Emphasizes	Regrets
Considers	Encourages	Reminds
Declares accordingly	Endorses	Requests
Deplores	Expresses its appreciation	Solemnly affirms
Designates	Expresses its hope	Strongly condemns
Draws the attention	Further invites	Supports
Emphasizes	Further proclaims	Takes note of
	Further reminds	Transmits
		Trusts

(Note: Clauses in Bold can only be used by the United Nations Security Council)

Sample Position Paper

Delegate's Name: ABC

Allocation: United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland

School: Welham Boys' School



Committee: United Nations Security Council

Agenda: Deliberating on Revitalising the Infrastructure and Development in Syria.

INTRODUCTION:

For over half a century, the heritage-rich nation of the Syrian Arab Republic has oscillated between autocracy and unrest. Following Hafez al-Assad's military coup in 1970, the country fell under the grip of Ba'athist authoritarianism. Under both Hafez and later his son Bashar al-Assad, dissent was crushed, minorities were marginalised, and the state's institutions became tools of repression. Syria projected an image of political imprisonment, economic stagnation, and brutal silencing of opposition. (Heydemann, 2018) In December 2024, after over a decade of civil war and stalemate conflict, the Assad regime in Syria collapsed following a swift military offensive by a coalition led by Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham (HTS), supported by Turkish-backed Syrian National Army forces and the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces. President Bashar al-Assad fled to Russia, ending more than five decades of Assad family rule. This power shift has significantly altered Syria's political landscape, leading to the establishment of a transitional government under HTS leader Ahmed al-Sharaa (Loft et. House of Commons Library, 2025). While the regime's downfall offers a chance for rebuilding and reform, there are several concerns regarding the potential resurgence of extremist groups and the challenges of establishing a stable, inclusive governance structure. Today, the conflict may have quieted in parts, but the suffering has not ended.

STANCE:

Accountability must come first—but the UK stands ready to support reconstruction when a credible, inclusive political process is underway. Rebuilding Syria cannot mean rebuilding the mechanisms of oppression. Development that is independent of justice would only reinforce the cycles of violence and impunity that brought the country to ruin (Loft et. House of Commons Library, 2025). The UK maintains that reconstruction funding must be conditional on guided, democratic and a genuine political transition and respect for international humanitarian law. London's role will remain clear: to aid Syria's recovery only in a framework that empowers its people, not its persecutors. Moreover, we must hold all criminals accountable for what they have done to the country. For this, the nation of Great Britain voted in favor of Resolution A/RES/71/248 and A/HRC/42/L.22, which respectively established the International, Impartial and Independent Mechanism (IIIM) to assist in the investigation and prosecution of those responsible for the most serious crimes under international law in Syria, and condemned the widespread human rights violations perpetrated by the Assad regime. The United Kingdom firmly supports the Syrian transitional government and recognizes it as a vital step toward lasting peace and legitimate governance. Unlike many in the West—who focus narrowly on military outcomes or economic deals—we understand that the foundation of a stable Syria lies in the architecture of its state: a representative constitution, accountable institutions, and unwavering commitment to anti-corruption (Chatham House, 2024). We believe in empowering Syrians to reclaim their sovereignty through democratic frameworks, rule of law, and inclusive dialogue. In



BACKGROUND GUIDE

March 2025, the UK went further, pledging up to £160 million in aid under a new Post-Assad Recovery and Stabilisation Initiative, focused on rebuilding civil infrastructure, retraining local governance institutions, and reopening schools and hospitals. Additionally, the UK announced the removal of asset freezes on 24 Syrian entities, including the Central Bank of Syria, as part of a calculated economic easing strategy designed to empower local rebuilding efforts without empowering war criminals. Subsequently, United Kingdom launched the Syria Education Programme II, committing up to £46 million, a five-year plan till 2027. This initiative is focused on delivering solid primary education in Northwest Syria, especially for the most vulnerable. This has taken full force since the start of the transition government (House of Commons Library, 2025).

PROPOSED SOLUTIONS:

The United Kingdom remains committed to playing an active role in Syria's reconstruction by offering substantial economic aid, technical expertise, and humanitarian support — contingent upon the establishment of a credible and inclusive political process. Our assistance spans infrastructure rehabilitation, the rebuilding of schools and hospitals, and capacity-building programs. However, the depth of our involvement will be calibrated to ensure transparency, accountability, and long-term sustainability. Given the economic challenges facing our own nation, including the strain on the NHS and the ongoing food crisis, we will NOT be engaging in the provision of liquid capital, having committed £3.7 Billion already. Whether it is the Assad regime or the transitional government, they must understand that diplomacy is essential — but not owed to everyone. Their continued reliance on actors such as Russia and Iran must be curtailed, and while the UK stands ready to support the United States in that effort, the same support does not extend unconditionally to all of its actions. Furthermore, in light of the European refugee crisis, the UK will take all necessary measures to prevent further displacement especially LIMITING refugees into our own nation while remaining firmly committed to the principles of the 1951 UN Refugee Convention to which we are a signatory. Negotiations will cover key areas such as security sector reform, economic restructuring, and the restoration of essential services, with flexible discussions on technical assistance and phased funding tied to clearly defined milestones. That said, matters of political accountability, adherence to international humanitarian law, and an unwavering commitment to ending impunity for war crimes are NON-NEGOTIABLE.

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